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Come to Stay



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IOWA BLUE

Honoring the Life and Fight of

BY **JOE PECK**

A ES



Robin Stone

Robin Stone was a passionate advocate for universal healthcare in a place where few were fighting for it — until she became another tragic victim of America's healthcare crisis.

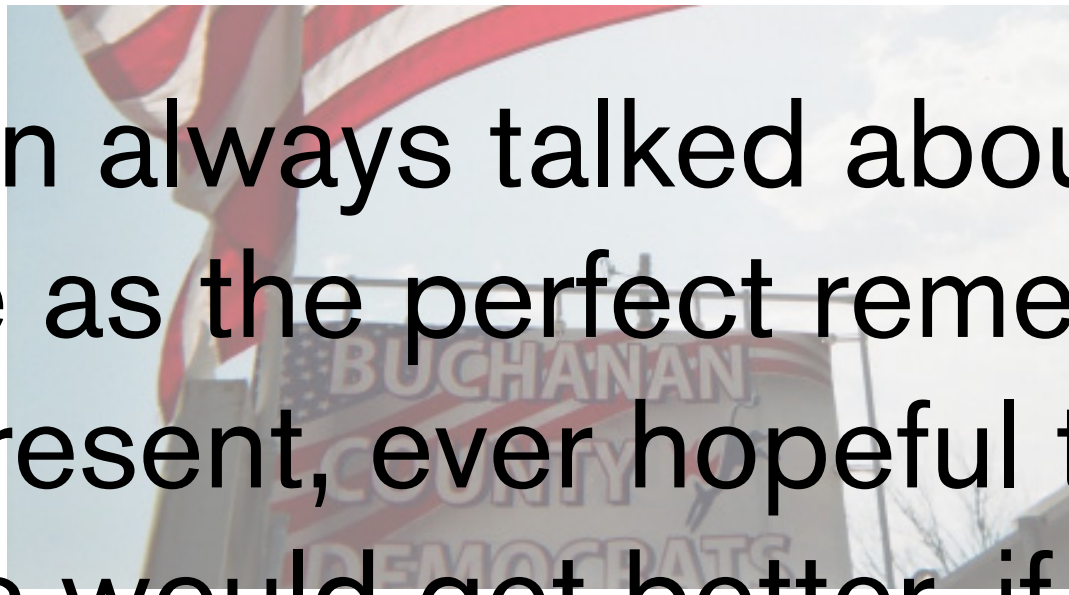
It's 11:30 in the morning, and the double-paned windows dull the hum of the cicadas outside. The fan whirs overhead and the AC unit shudders in the back room, creating a slow-burning cacophony almost as suffocating as the heat. This is rural Iowa, flyover country. And on this Saturday morning, in the small town of Manchester, people are gearing up for the event of the year: the annual Delaware County Fair.

Robin Stone, the chair of the Delaware County Democratic Party, has been thinking about this week for a while. This area swung hard for Trump in the 2016 presidential election, but still has strong Democratic roots. Robin is keen to prove that her band of aging, hardworking Democrats is not going anywhere.

As I walk out into the street, into the hot wall of thick air and away from the AC, I see Robin already rallying her troops outside the house. At the age of 63, unfazed by the suffocating heat, she is organizing the construction of a float for the fair's car parade. "This is our chance to show off a bit," she tells me, with a small, satisfied smile before immediately getting back to work on the float.

Manchester native Jim Kernan will be driving a pick-up truck, which drags the six-by-fourteen foot trailer lined with hay bales. Between the bales stands a placard that had been painted the night before by Carol Hennessy, from the neighboring town of Ryan, which reads "2020 VISION" in huge, rounded letters above a cartoonish image of the White House. Sharie Kernan, Jim's wife, brings out a radio to play the Beach Boys during the parade. "Everyone loves the Beach Boys," she says. Within a few hours, the float is ready to go.

At around 4:00 in the afternoon, the parade finally sets off through the streets of Manchester. Jim's trail-



“Robin always talked abou future as the perfect reme the present, ever hopeful t things would get better, if you worked for it.”

er is loaded with 15 people on either side of the placard, all squeezed in along the bales of hay and waving hand-sized American flags. Onlookers are seated on their front porches, under the shade of the ash trees that line the streets. Every house applauds as the float passes by. The Beach Boys CD must be on its third go-around, but no one is really listening anyway. Robin made sure to buy some candy to give to the younger parade watchers. “This way they’ll be Democrats someday,” she laughs.

Sharie grasps Robin’s shoulder, “This is fun,” she says, “Thank you.” Robin smiles and turns back to the curb-side crowd.

Next year, Manchester will elect a new mayor, and everyone I spoke with thinks Robin will take the top job. She is the soul of this town. As she sits atop the float, talking to her friends and smiling at the people who line the sidewalk, it makes sense. “Go Bernie!” shouts a passer-by. “No, go you!” Robin replies. Even in this conservative part of rural Iowa, Robin’s battle-hardened Democrats are always fighting for their values. It is to Robin’s credit that they always do so with a smile on their faces.

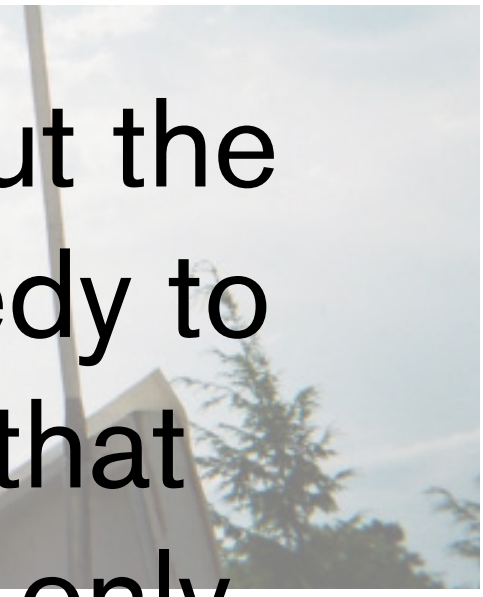
I first met Robin Stone during a late evening with the Delaware County Party a month before the parade, in June 2019. I was in Iowa working for Elizabeth Warren’s presidential campaign, but in my free time took the opportunity to meet as many local Democrats as possible. Usually, the monthly meetings of the Democratic Party are kept indoors, to hide from the yellow heat of those muggy Iowa nights, but that night was sufficiently temperate for a meeting al fresco.

The picnic area across the street from long-time-volunteer Carol Hennessy’s house also afforded more space for this month’s sizable attendance. The campaign for the Iowa caucuses was heating up, and most of the presidential campaigns had sent their representatives to the meeting. On one of the dozen picnic tables, Governor Jay Inslee’s guy was talking about climate policy and, on another, Governor Steve Bullock’s organizer discussed the rural economy. The Democratic faithful did not seem to really care either way; they had seen hundreds of campaign staffers pass through this town, most fresh out of college and none seen in Delaware County ever again. For the time being, the members of the local Democratic Party remained uncommitted to a single candidate and were simply enjoying the attention.

After Robin called the meeting to order, a hush fell over the 40 or so attendees. An audacious Pete Buttigieg worker was still rattling on about Midwestern values. An older, more disciplined local promptly put him in his place. The elder Democrat reminded him that no one talks over the chair. Robin looked on silently, gave her signature slight smile, and started the meeting.

About an hour later, after the meeting had concluded, I sat down to talk to her alone. Her short, scarlet red hair complimented her bold, red glasses, and sharply contrasted the muted fashion of most of her fellow Iowans. She seemed like a product of Provincetown or Seattle and spoke with a fluency that complimented her cheeky charm. At one point she leaned in towards me and, in defiance of party rules about county chairs endorsing candidates, said, “I’m for Warren,” followed by that smile. “I’d love to see Trump get beaten by a girl.”

Two weeks later, Robin invited me to a debate watch party at her house. It was the first debate after six months of town halls and diner visits, and the candidates had a nation’s attention for the first time. With Sanders, Biden, and some of



the more raucous candidates relegated to the second night of arguments, the show on the television was fairly tame. Robin started talking to me about healthcare policy and revealed she was already something of a local celebrity. In the midst of the Republican fight to repeal the Affordable Care Act (ACA) in 2017, Robin attended a town hall with Senator Chuck Grassley (R-IA), who had voted seven times to repeal the healthcare law. An argument ensued between the two. "You're threatening my life," she told him, to which the statesman looked visibly shaken. It was reported on state news the following day and made it all the way to "The Last Word" with Lawrence O'Donnell on MSNBC the week after.

"I would be dead if it wasn't for the Affordable Care Act," Robin told me between bites of pizza as Beto O'Rourke soliloquized on the television. "Obama saved my life, and now all they want to do is take it all away and leave me with nothing," she said, stating that the ACA allowed her to gain insurance for the first time. Her upset was masked by the anger in her voice. "This is why this election is so important."

Then, unprovoked: "You know, I've already booked tickets to the Democratic National Convention in Milwaukee. I figured there might be something going on, so I'd better show up." She smiled. Robin always talked about the future as the perfect remedy to the present, ever hopeful that things would get better, if only you worked for it. Then Elizabeth Warren started speaking on the TV, and Robin hushed everyone in the room. "Be quiet, I want to hear this." Warren was speaking in favor of universal healthcare. "Yes!" Robin exclaimed, looking through her thick, red glasses at the screen. "She's a feisty woman—I like that."

As the debate wrapped up and Robin's husband, Mark, collected the pizza plates, Robin started thinking aloud. "The trouble is, you can't have an insurance-based system because so many people can't afford it." Robin paused, but nobody spoke. Over the course of the past year, it had become an unspoken rule of Democratic Party meetings not to speak about Medicare for All, as it was the topic that divided the party more than any other. But Robin didn't care.

"I won't have any money left by the end of the summer, I can't go on like this," she said, to which her invitees sympathetically and silently looked on. Robin had type two diabetes and had lost all feeling in her legs. She had been able to gain insurance through the ACA's protections for patients with pre-existing conditions, but countless hospital appointments and deductibles had rendered her near-bankrupt.

"Look at this," she said to me, holding up the healthcare.gov website on her phone, "It says 'After you spend this amount on deductibles, co-payments, and coinsurance for in-network care and services, your health plan pays 100 percent of the costs of covered benefits.'" She paused for a second.

"That's not good enough. After all those deductibles and copayments, I won't have anything left." Her husband was still clearing up from the party. He walked up to Robin, put his hand on her back, and kissed her on the head. By the time Robin had finished talking, they both had tears in their eyes.

In late July, 2019, about a month after the debate watch party, I was in West Union, Iowa, two hours north of Manchester. A frail, octogenarian woman by the name of Dorothy Walters was telling me about her successful mayoral campaign in 1988, when she became the first female mayor of the town.

"It was amazing," she said, "nobody thought I would win. Hell, I didn't think I would win. That night, I opened up City Hall to the public and threw a huge party. I called it the Mayor's Ball," she laughed. "Everyone came and we partied into the night. The papers weren't very happy about it the next day, but I didn't care, we made history!"

Mayor Walters and I talked about her time as mayor. She only served for two years—the best two years of her life. Then, someone in the room mentioned that the local CBS station in Waterloo interviewed Robin Stone the previous night. Mayor Walters flung her head towards them, "Robin Stone," she said, "I love her."

"How do you know Robin?" I asked. "Are you kidding, she's the girl who gave Chuck Grassley hell!" Walters said.

When I said goodbye to Robin outside her home in early August, she looked over her classic red rims and said "don't ever stop fighting for the things that matter." She gave me a hug, walked to her front door, and went inside. It was a thick Wednesday afternoon, and the cicadas still droned throughout the town. As I walked home, I became keenly aware of the sticky coating of insect repellent and sunscreen covering my skin, which easily picks up the dust of the Iowa summer.

As I entered my house, passing from the outdoor hum to the hum of recycled air, I thought of Robin Stone. She looked as well as she had when I met her three months prior. Yet, something was missing from her, something she had when she beamed

with joy at the Delaware County Fair. She had recently learned that she was going to be a grandmother to a baby girl due in the fall, but she was terrified that complications arising from her diabetes would catch up to her and kill her before the baby came. In these last days of the summer, money and illness haunted Robin—and the prospect of her recovery was dying with the daylight.

The next time I encountered the name Robin Stone was in late September, on her daughter Katie's Facebook account. On top of Robin's existing medical problems, she had collapsed and was rushed to hospital, where she was eventually diagnosed with anaplastic thyroid cancer, a particularly vicious form of cancer that requires immediate attention. Robin, Mark, and Katie were told to go to the best place for specialist care, the Mayo Clinic in northern Iowa. The Manchester general hospital could organize transport if necessary.

Robin had insurance. There was only one problem: the Mayo Clinic was out-of-network, meaning the hospital did not accept her insurance, and officials at the hospital had demanded $16,000 just to let her in the door. Robin could not afford that. She could never afford that. Her best chance at survival was lost almost as soon as it appeared. Instead, her doctor decided that the Manchester hospital should operate to remove her thyroid as soon as possible. Manchester's doctors and equipment were not as specialized as those at the Mayo Clinic, but the seriousness of the disease posed too great a risk to her life to wait any longer. The treatment was going to be started in early October.

When I called Robin about a week after her diagnosis, her prospects had already taken yet another turn for the worse. Her insurance was tied to her employer: a small hospice company operating out of Manchester. But they had decided to change Robin's healthcare coverage shortly before her operation. "They dropped me," Robin told me over the phone, holding back tears, "they dropped one of my health insurance plans days before I was supposed to receive treatment for my cancer. Days," she repeated. Robin was still expecting to receive treatment by the second week of October, but she would now be loaded with exorbitant, unpayable debt. Faced with a choice between that and not being treated at all, it was obvious what she had to do.

But by then it was too late.

Robin never spoke again. Following a tracheostomy, she was reduced to typing on an iPhone screen and writing down her thoughts on a paper pad by the side of her hospital bed. She was barely able to stay awake for most of the day and, because of the risk of infection, only a limited number of guests could see her. On October 22, Senator Bernie Sanders (I-VT) shared a picture of Robin and her daughter Katie on his Twitter account, alongside the blunt phrase, "This is the human cost of our profit-driven health care system." Robin thanked him in the replies for sharing her story.

On October 31, she tweeted Senator Grassley farewell, saying "you won't have to worry about me bugging you about the ACA. I have anaplastic thyroid cancer and will die soon. But there's a whole army of activists picking up where I'm leaving off." She finished off her tweet with the simple line, "You're a coward."

Senator Grassley called her shortly after, but Robin, bedridden and unable to talk, merely listened. There wasn't much else she could have done. She died two days later, on November 2, 2019.

Robin was survived by her husband Mark and her daughter Katie, and 20,000 dollars worth of medical debt. Two weeks later, at 10:43 p.m. on November 16, Robin's granddaughter, Aniya Charliann Mitchell, was born at Manchester Regional Medical Center, weighing six pounds, seven ounces.

To her last breath, Robin Stone represented the very kindest of America. Her passion to build a better society never faltered, and her humor was as consistent as the faint smile that followed almost everything she said. The wonder of her character was completely incongruous to the tragedy she faced at the hands of America's unforgiving and cruel healthcare crisis.

When I asked Robin in July, 2019, what she wanted to be remembered for, she paused, thought for a second, and then replied with her classic smile. "Well, in my Twitter bio I have the words 'unapologetically liberal.' I think I'd put that on my gravestone." She laughed. Then, quoting Margaret Mead, she advised: "Never doubt that a small group of thoughtful, committed citizens can change the world; indeed, it's the only thing that ever has."

MYANMAR IN CRISIS

Amid the Struggle for Democracy, Where Do the Rohingya Belong?

BY **CAMERON FREEMAN**

Several weeks ago, Myanmar's military abducted David Stanley's uncle. "Hopefully he's still alive," Stanley said. Stanley, a Yale sophomore raised in Myanmar, fled the country as a child in 2007. He and his family hid in Malaysia for two and a half years before receiving asylum in the United States through the United Nations. "He is an artist, so he used his platform to speak out against the military junta," Stanley said. "And we haven't heard from him. And we're very nervous."

On February 1, Myanmar's military, known as the Tatmadaw, seized power from the country's democratically-elected leadership after baseless claims of election fraud. Though the coup itself was bloodless, the military crackdown on democratic protests in its wake has killed and wounded hundreds. After just a decade of nascent democracy, pre-coup leader Aung San Suu Kyi and her National League for Democracy (NLD) party remain immensely popular.

The return of military rule represents a disastrous step backward to the merciless pre-democracy junta government Burmese remember all too well.

"I remember talking to my dad, he was just distraught because he remembered how awful living under

“He is an artist, so he used his platform to speak out against the military junta,” Stanley said. “And we haven’t heard from him. And we’re very nervous.”

the previous regime was,” said Stanley.

Many members of the old junta compose the new government, and the military’s bloody attacks demonstrate that the Tatmadaw is as brutal as ever. “It definitely seems like it’s the same people running things as before,” said Elliott Prasse-Freeman, a Myanmar scholar at the National University of Singapore. According to Prasse-Freeman, members of the military take pride in the fact that they have never split.

For the protests to succeed, soldiers would likely have to defect en masse. But this doesn’t seem probable, despite the overall popularity of the democracy movement. Soldiers remain committed to the military cause—or at least fear the military too much to defect, according to Prasse-Freeman.

“Over 600 people have been killed,” Stanley said. “It really hurts me. There are some nights where I just can’t sleep just thinking about people who are in my situation who have such bright futures and now it’s ruined.”

The return of harsh autocratic rule erased the hope that democratization brought many Burmese people—but even during the past decade, the benefits of democracy were never evenly shared. Persecuted ethnic minority groups, including the Muslim-majority Rohingya, faced intense discrimination which escalated into ethnic cleansing.

Though some young protesters have called for trans-ethnic solidarity during the recent protests, exclusivist Buddhist nationalists will likely dominate government for the foreseeable future. The ethno-nationalist Tatmadaw will undoubtedly continue to mercilessly persecute minority Burmese. Even if protesters can reestablish democracy against the odds, history has shown that Myanmar’s democratically-elected leaders often rally around a majoritarian ethnic identity. Any realistic democratic future offers little hope for persecuted minorities like the Rohingya.

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After decades of activism and protest, democracy in Myanmar is synonymous with Aung San Suu Kyi.

Suu Kyi is "just like our mother," Stanley told *The Politic*. In the eyes of many in Myanmar, she embodies selflessness. "She's been fighting for this her whole life," Stanley explained.

The daughter of Myanmar's independence hero General Aung San, Suu Kyi once commanded both immense domestic and international respect. After studying at Oxford University in the 1960s and living abroad for the following two decades, Suu Kyi returned to Myanmar in 1988 to care for her sick mother. While there, she emerged as a national icon amid the student-led campaign of peaceful pro-democracy protests known as the 8888 Uprising.

A one-party military government had ruled the nation since 1962. Their ideology, the Burmese Way to Socialism, devastated Myanmar's economy and transformed it into one of the poorest nations in Asia. By 1988, many Burmese people had tired of the regime's disastrous rule. Yet just weeks after millions marched for democracy, the military seized exclusive power over the government and rapidly suppressed demonstrations. State security forces killed and tortured thousands of protesters and eventually placed Suu Kyi under house arrest in mid-1989.

What is now Myanmar had been for generations called Burma. Military leaders, desperate to improve the country's reputation, suddenly discarded its name—seen as a scrap of its colonial past—in favor of Myanmar in 1989. The government claimed the new name would better represent ethnic minorities. But in the Burmese language, "Myanmar" is simply a formal version of "Burma." There was little change beyond mere symbolism: Myanmar's government represented the diversity of its people in name only.

To bolster their credibility, the junta agreed to hold parliamentary elections in 1990. They expected to win an easy victory, given major barriers to opposition participation. Nonetheless, Suu Kyi's NLD won more than 80 percent of seats contested. The military refused to relinquish power and annulled the results.

In 1991, the Nobel Prize committee awarded the Peace Prize to Suu Kyi, lauding her non-violent efforts to enact democratic regime change and her bravery in the face of a brutal dictatorship. Between 1989 and 2010, Suu Kyi was kept under house arrest for 15 years. For years, it was a crime to utter her name. During her brief years of freedom, her political activities and movements were heavily restricted. Because she would likely be denied reentry if she left, Suu Kyi remained in Myanmar.

In 2010, the military allowed the first parliamentary elections since 1990 under the 2008 military-drafted Constitution. According to Prasse-Freeman, there is no consensus on why the Tatmadaw enacted this democratic transition. Perhaps the junta expected to retain their de-facto power and status while reaping the economic benefits of liberalization. One theory posits that the coup was always intended to occur after the economic boost provided by democratization.

Critically, the junta effectively barred Suu Kyi from participating in the election by charging her with a crime and enacting a targeted law barring convicted criminals from electoral activities. In protest of the junta's restrictions on fair elections, the NLD refused to re-register as a party, dissolving the organization. Without a viable opposition, the military's party analog, the Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP), achieved a massive electoral win amid accusations of voter fraud.

Despite the longstanding efforts to hamper Suu Kyi's activism, just six days after the 2010 elections, the government released Suu Kyi and lifted many of the restrictions on her political activities.

With widespread international praise, Suu Kyi was elected to Myanmar's parliament in 2012. And, for the first time, Myanmar's 2015 general elections were largely free. Despite state media control and a law mandating that 25% of parliamentary seats must be held by unelected military representatives, Suu Kyi's reinstated NLD managed to again win 80% of contested seats for a clear majority. This time, the NLD was allowed to take power.

Although her party had won, Suu Kyi remained barred from the presidency due to a technical formality in the constitution. In response, the newly empowered NLD created a new role, State Counsellor, which allowed Suu Kyi to rule by proxy. Her parliamentary ally Htin Kyaw assumed the office of the presidency.

The international optimism surrounding Myanmar's first liberal democratic government soon faded.

In a bid for popular support, Suu Kyi and the NLD embraced majoritarian nationalist sentiments, isolating Burmese minorities. "In Myanmar, what emerged out of democratization was a kind of an accommodation between the military regime and the Aung San Suu Kyi's civilian government," said David Simon, Director of Yale's Genocide Studies Program, in an interview with *The Politic*. "What they agreed upon was this majoritarian view, in which minorities did not deserve equal standing. And in other words, it was okay to persecute minorities," Simon explained.

Burma is highly diverse, with well over 100 recognized ethnicities. Almost 70 percent of the nation belong to the Bamar group, who are almost universally Buddhist. In all, nearly 90 percent of Burmese practice Buddhism.

The Muslim-majority Rohingya are Myanmar's most visible minority group. They have for years suffered appalling institutional and societal discrimination along ethnic and religious lines.

After gaining independence from Britain in 1948, Burmese nationalists drew from the majority Bamar ethnic identity and a long history of

Buddhism to fashion a Burmese identity to unify their fractured former colony. But they excluded minorities who did not fit that ideal, forging a political narrative that the Rohingya—who were geographically isolated in the western part of the country—were foreigners.

In 1982, the government formally stripped the Rohingya of their citizenship. Though Rohingya have lived in Myanmar for centuries, nationalists continue to claim they are illegal immigrants. Today, laws restricting "marriage, family planning, employment, education, religious choice, and freedom of movement" constrain the Rohingya.

After a series of attacks by Rohingya militants on police stations on August 25, 2017, anti-Rohingya sentiments flared. Though the military had attacked Rohingya villages as early as 2012, the weeks and months following the 2017 attacks brought new levels of violence. Aided by irregular militias, the Tatmadaw mounted a ruthless and deadly campaign against Rohingya civilians. According to estimates from Doctors Without Borders, at least 6,700 Rohingya, including 730 children, were murdered between August 25 and September 24, 2017. Rohingya villages were burned, and the military carried out widespread atrocities against women and children. Soldiers opened fire on fleeing civilians, planted land mines at border crossing areas into Bangladesh, and engaged in widespread sexual violence. In total, around 24,000 civilians were killed.

"The violence against the Rohingya in Myanmar rises to the level of genocide," Simon said. "The motivations for violence against the Rohingya may have been to clear them out of the land. The intent for the violence was to cause bodily harm, to kill, and force relocation."

According to UN estimates, these attacks drove more than 742,000 Rohingya to flee their homes in the western Rakhine State, most of whom arrived at Bangladeshi refugee camps within three months of the crisis. They joined more than 150,000 refugees already present in overcrowded and dangerous living conditions. More than 40 percent of the refugees are under the age of 12. Children have no access to education in the camps, and the population is at serious risk of disease. Around 60 percent of the water supply across the camps is contaminated.

The actions of Myanmar's military received swift international condemnation. A September 2018 UN report describing the severity of the atrocities described "genocidal intent" and recommends that "named senior generals of the Myanmar military should be investigated and prosecuted in an international criminal tribunal for genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes."

Stanley questions whether Suu Kyi had the power to stop the military's attacks. "I know where Aung San Suu Kyi is coming from. If you say anything they will kill you," Stanley said. "I understand that people are accusing her of [contributing to] the Rohingya situation," he continued. "But when you think about it, it all started because of the military."

The political strength of the military—even after the installation of Suu Kyi's civilian government—was safeguarded by constitutional clauses which guaranteed military control over home affairs, defense, and border affairs.

Yet Suu Kyi actively defended the military. "She was willing to sell out these people," said Prasse-Freeman. "In order to look good to nationalists and to outflank, to out right-wing, the military."

Suu Kyi's pandering reached its pinnacle in her highly publicized 2019 appearance before the International Court of Justice in The Hague, becoming the first head of state to testify as an alleged genocide occurred. Her decision to attend surprised even Myanmar's military.

In The Hague, she doubled down on claims that the Tatmadaw was simply addressing an internal conflict with brutal Muslim militants. In her half-hour speech, she refused to mention the Rohingya by name, in what was perceived widely as a refusal to recognize the group's legitimacy.

Though Suu Kyi's personal defense of Myanmar's atrocities was met with international scorn, her popularity rose at home, and her NLD party handily won a majority of seats in the November 2020 elections. Yet, unlike in 2015, the military-backed opposition party disputed the results, accusing the government of election-rigging and calling for a re-run.

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Khing Hnin Wai spent the morning of February 1, 2021 dancing to techno music along the Yaza Htarni Road leading to Myanmar's parliament in Naypyidaw. Wai, an online aerobics instructor, was filming a workout video for a fitness competition. As the surreal video unfolds, her neon exercise clothing and energetic moves soon contrast with an intimidating stream of dark military vehicles cruising toward parliament. Unwittingly, Wai had captured on film the bloodless February coup that stunned the world.

Three months ago, the day before new members or parliamentary were to be sworn in, the Tatmadaw deposed the government. Declaring a year-long state of emergency, the military cut phone lines and blocked internet service. Soldiers arrested Suu Kyi and NLD leadership under charges later revealed to include the violation of COVID-19 guidelines and import restrictions on foreign communications equipment—including walkie-talkies—found in her villa. Suu Kyi could receive a total of six years in prison.

Though rumors of a coup had circulated internationally in the days before the power grab, the military's actions shocked some proponents of democracy. "Everyone was just in disbelief because we thought we're past that stage," Stanley recalled. "It didn't even take two days until things just escalated."

Soon after the coup, hundreds of thousands of protesters took to the streets in cities across the country. Burmese of all generations and profes-

sions attended. As in 1988, young people spearheaded the movement known as the Civil Disobedience Movement.

In response to coordinated work stoppages to protest the coup, the military announced a suspension of Burmese civil liberties on February 13, allowing for indefinite detention and warrantless police raids. The next day, the military moved armored vehicles and thousands of soldiers into cities across the country in a significant show of force. State security forces shot protesters with rubber bullets and water cannons, while vehicles surrounded the homes of dissenting government officials.

Organizing through social media and messaging apps, the decentralized protest movement continued to grow, despite an extensive military firewall and internet blackouts. The streets of major cities overflowed with protesters.

In response, the military turned to a time-honored tactic: indiscriminate violence. On February 28, the military began a more drastic approach. On the bloodiest day since the coup, troops fired on hundreds of people, killing 18 protesters in Yangon, Mandalay, Bago, Dawei, Myeik, and Pakokku.

Over the course of March, the violence escalated. In total, security forces have killed more than 600 protesters.

"I don't understand this narrative that Myanmar is on the brink of civil war. It is a civil war," Mary Callahan, a University of Washington professor, told NPR.

The violence of the military shocked the Burmese public. "Two days ago, my hometown was raided. Now they're using RPGs," Stanley said. "There's no sense of humanity left in them."

The outlook for the Rohingya is as precarious as the democratic future of Myanmar. Many minority Burmese, some watching from refugee camps in Bangladesh, view Suu Kyi's fate as just deserts for her betrayal of minority Burmese.

Perhaps the violence that the military has unleashed on pro-democracy protesters may lead the general public to recognize the extent of the government's cruelty against the Rohingya, and thus, draw greater sympathy to the persecuted minority. Ronan Lee, a scholar with the International State Crime Initiative, told *Voice of America* that some protesters have now begun to question their silence when the military brutalized Rohingya civilians. Continued active resistance against the coup, he argued, may create an opportunity for the country to firmly eject the military from its position of political power.

"No one wants the military in place," Stanley highlighted. "So under that same umbrella, I think they can definitely unite all of us."

Some Rohingya have openly joined the protests, while other non-Rohingya have held signs supporting the Rohingya cause. Unlike previous protests, many are using signs, memes, and chants to promote inclusivity—messages explicitly designed to influence other protesters. "While the protests are directed at a common enemy, they're really a horizontal communication with other potential democrats," said Prasse-Freeman.

"First they came for the Karens [an ethnic group] and we didn't speak out. Then they came for the Rohingya and we didn't speak out. Now they are coming for all of us," one sign read.

Though this nascent trans-ethnic movement offers some promise, the future looks less hopeful. Some young protesters want to reimagine Myanmar's politics entirely to make the nation more pluralistic. Yet this fundamental transformation would require a rejection of Suu Kyi's mainstream conception of liberalism.

Simon is not confident this change can occur. "The experience of the Aung San Suu Kyi regime leaves me pretty pessimistic about the ability of democracy, as it has been practiced in Myanmar off and on for the last 50 years, to protect the rights of minorities."

He points to their history as a bleak indicator for future change: "If they succeed in getting the military out, the next step will be to consolidate power." He continued, "In the past, when that's happened, the political forces that have risen to the top have been this majoritarian anti-pluralist version of politics."

Prasse-Freeman highlighted the precarious situation for democracy supporters who are minorities. "The position that ethnic groups and people are finding themselves in is that they're wondering if, as one person put it, 'when things become okay for the Bamar, will they just forget us like they did before?'"

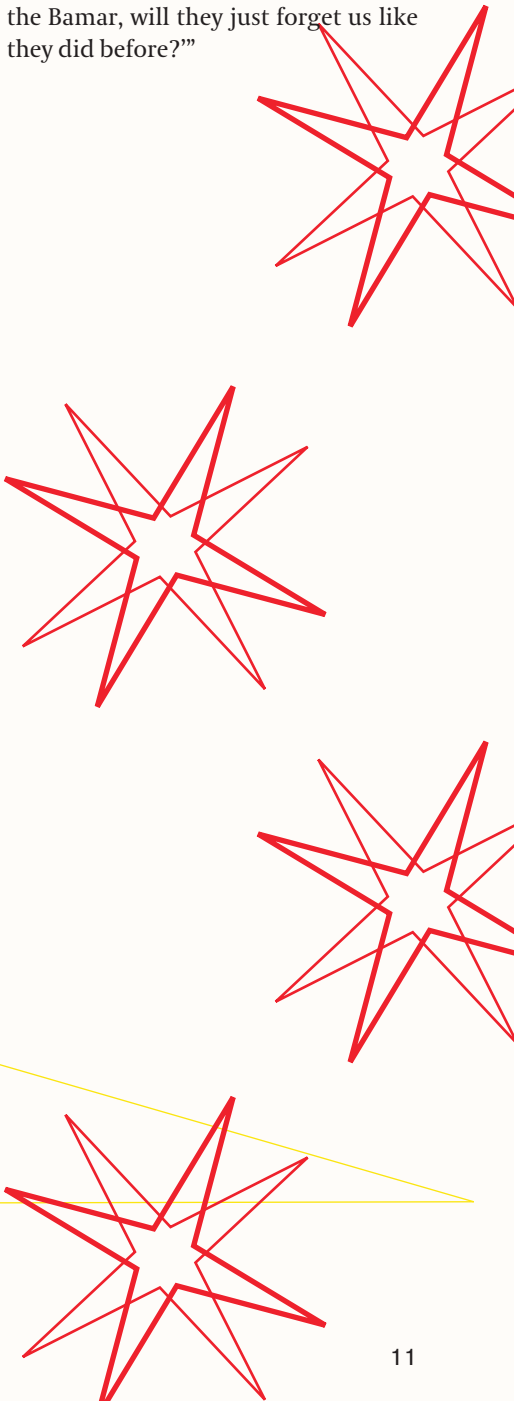




Image Credit: *The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York*

Systemic Racism in Jury Selection

BY **NOEL SIMS**

In 1996, Allen Snyder, a Black man from Louisiana, faced charges for first degree murder.

He was on trial in Jefferson Parish, a place where a plurality of voters had cast their ballots for Ku Klux Klan Grand Wizard David Duke in Louisiana's gubernatorial election just four years earlier.

Snyder was convicted by an all white jury and sentenced to death.

He appealed his conviction on the basis of an unrepresentative jury until his case arrived at the Supreme Court in 2008, where Stephen B. Bright, the current Harvey L. Karp Visiting Lecturer in Law at Yale Law School, argued successfully on his behalf.

Bright told *The Politic* that Mr. Snyder's situation was a common one, though his ultimate triumph was unique. Black defendants across the country are routinely tried by all white juries. Most, however, do not make it on the docket of the Supreme Court—which may be their only hope to have their sentence repealed.

The Sixth Amendment to the Constitution guarantees defendants two things: the right to a trial by an impartial jury, and the right to trial by a jury of their peers. But Black jurors, like those in Snyder's case, are regularly excluded from serving on juries by a series of legal practices that are rooted in systemic racism and the belief that the life experience of Black jurors renders them incapable of being impartial.

"I have seen case after case where the only person of color in the front of the courtroom, in front of the bar, is the defendant. The judge is white, the prosecutor is white, the court appointed lawyers are white," Bright told *The Politic*. "And even in communities that have fairly substantial Black populations, the jury is all white."

Bright's observation raises the question of whether the current criminal justice system fulfills the Constitution's promises to Black defendants.

Activists, lawyers, and policy experts alike agree that the jury selection system is broken at every stage of the process—and Black defendants are paying the price.

In 1982, James Kirkland Batson, a Black man from Kentucky, was on trial for burglary. During his trial, prosecutor Joe Gutmann used a tool called peremptory strikes to remove six jurors, including each of the four Black jurors remaining in the jury pool — hoping that a jury which looked nothing like Batson would be more likely to convict him.

Batson lived and grew up in a predominantly Black neighborhood of Louisville. A jury of his peers, a fair cross-section of the community, should have included Black jurors.

But because of Gutmann's use of a legal tool called peremptory strikes, the jury was completely white. Though Batson pleaded innocent, he was sentenced to 20 years in prison.

Peremptory strikes and strikes for cause are the final chance for either party in a case to shape the jury by removing jurors they believe cannot assess the case impartially. Varying by jurisdiction, each party has a certain number of strikes for cause and peremptory strikes they can make. Strikes for cause must be explained and approved by the judge.

But peremptory strikes require no explanation and can be used for any

reason—except, theoretically, race.

Yet many allege that prosecutors still routinely use these strikes to remove people of color from juries precisely because of their race, often hiding their true rationale in coded or deceptive language and explanations.

Batson and his attorney attempted to object to the elimination of the Black jurors, but their challenge was not accepted. Batson appealed his conviction, eventually making it to the Supreme Court. Leading up to the trial, Batson's attorneys conducted novel research to show that prosecutors were using peremptory strikes in a discriminatory manner nationwide, from California to Kentucky to Connecticut. In countless trials, Black defendants, like Batson, were tried by all white juries and given lengthy prison time—or even death sentences.

The Supreme Court decided in 1986 that the Kentucky court had denied James Batson his Sixth and Fourteenth Amendment rights by denying him the right to a fair trial by a jury of his peers and equal protection under the law.

In its decision on *Batson v. Kentucky,* the court created the Batson rule: If one party in a trial feels that the other has used a peremptory strike to remove a juror specifically because of their race, they may raise a Batson challenge requiring the other party to provide a "race-neutral" reason for the strike. If this race-neutral reason is sufficient, the court may deny the challenge.

The Batson rule was revolutionary — or at least it was supposed to be.

As in Batson's case, prosecutors used peremptory strikes to make Snyder's jury completely white. It was under the *Batson* precedent that his verdict was overturned. But his case was the exception, not the norm.

The concern that a shared racial background makes jurors less likely to reach a guilty verdict incentivizes prosecutors to use peremptory strikes to eliminate jurors. As a loophole to *Batson*, prosecutors quickly developed a list of "race-neutral" reasons for striking a juror that could be recited on the spot in the event of a Batson challenge: the juror lives in the same neighborhood as the defendant, the juror has expressed mistrust for law enforcement, the juror has a family member in prison, the juror has long nails, the juror cannot maintain eye contact.

Explanations for peremptory strikes facing a Batson challenge have become increasingly trivial, according to Bright. He lamented that even as a jury must "decide a case about whether a person lives or dies, the prosecutors are worried about whether a juror wears sunglasses or not."

These justifications have been used successfully to overturn Batson challenges and maintain discriminatory peremptory strikes in real cases. They are among the many that certain jurisdictions still accept as "race-neutral."

Truthfully, these statements are anything but. They originate from the effects of systemic racism—and perpetuate it.

Black jurors are more likely to live in the same neighborhood as the defendant due to generational cycles of redlining and gentrification. Black jurors are more likely to express distrust of law enforcement because Black Americans are subject to brutality by the police more regularly than Americans of other races. Black jurors are more likely to have an incarcerated family member because Black Americans are routinely given longer sentences for less serious crimes — and in all likelihood, that incarcerated relative would have been tried by a jury that looked nothing like them.

In a cruelly ironic way, the process required to enact the Batson rule itself perpetuates systemic racism under the guise of impartiality. To accept a Batson challenge, Bright explained, "the judge has to make two findings: one, intentional race discrimination, and two, the prosecutor lied about the reason for their strike." But Bright reasoned that few judges are willing to say that to or about lawyers who may have once been their associates. "That is a harsh thing to accuse someone of, even if it may be true."

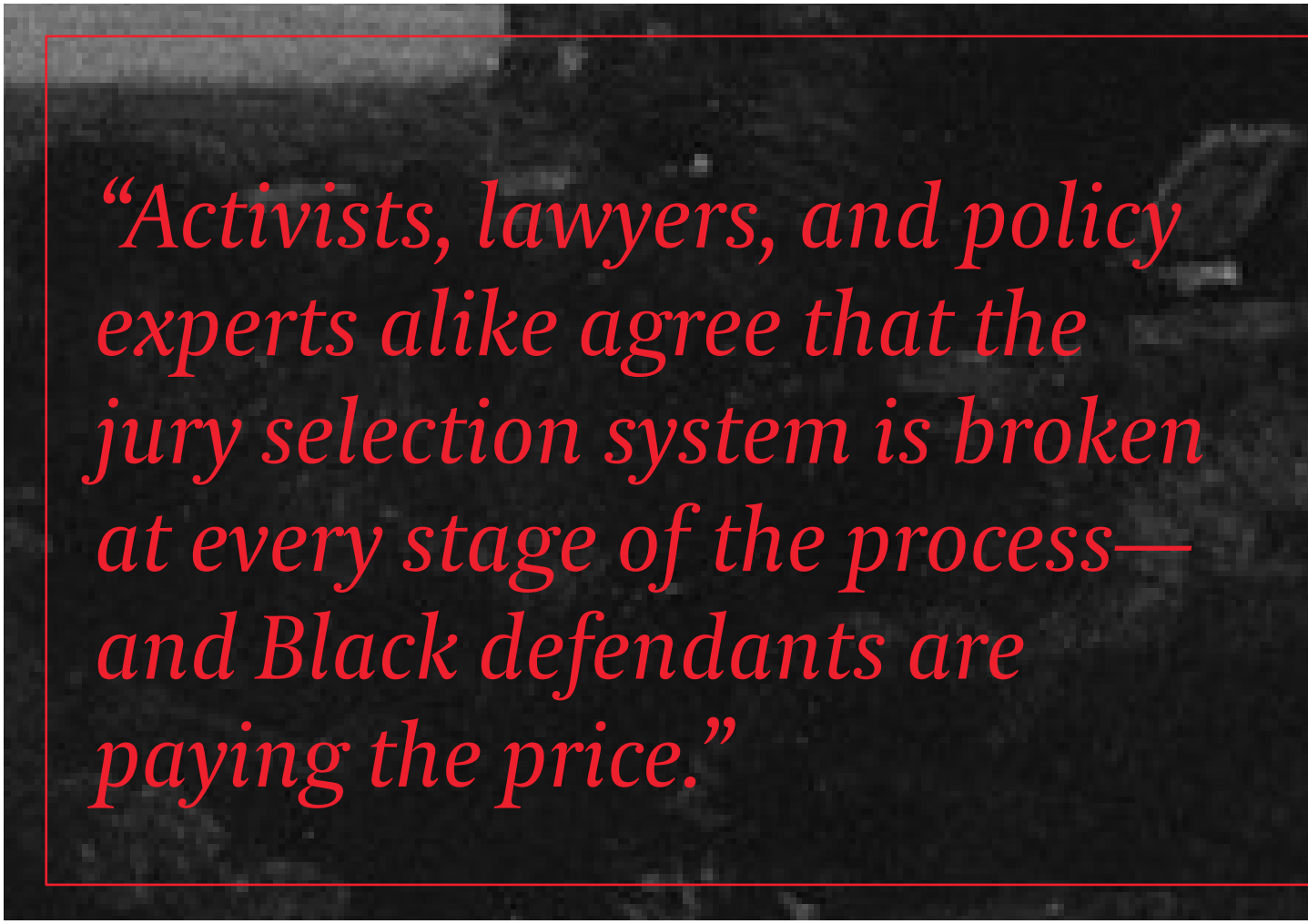
If a Batson challenge is raised, but not accepted by the judge, the potential juror in question is removed. So when, for personal reasons, judges are not inclined to accept Batson challenges, the rule becomes essentially toothless.

"A lot of judges were prosecutors themselves," Bright noted, describing the social and political factors that make many judges unwilling to approve Batson challenges in their courtrooms. "They used to strike all the Black people when they were prosecutors, and now they are judges, and their chief assistant is the prosecutor."

The Batson rule made the exclusion of Black Americans from juries a longer process, but an end that was no less achievable. Even 35 years later, all white juries routinely try Black defendants.

In June 2020, Professor Elisabeth Semel, who leads the Death Penalty Clinic at UC Berkeley's law school, and a group of her students released a report entitled "Whitewashing the Jury Box." The report investigates the impact of peremptory strikes on jury diversity in the state of California, where proportionate representation of Black and Latino citizens in jury pools is a goal that has not yet been achieved.

According to Semel, lawyers like herself are meant to use peremptory strikes when "they have a good faith belief that the juror cannot be fair, and



yet for reasons very specific to that juror or the circumstances cannot meet [the criteria of] the cause challenge."

In many instances, it is easy to see how peremptory strikes may help prevent biased jurors from judging a case.

"There was that person who just stared at your client, and maybe we misinterpreted the stare, but the client says 'she hates me,' just walking into the courtroom." Potential jurors may cause concern for a lawyer or client, though they may not be able to articulate exactly why. "You want to be able to strike those people," former public defender Andrew Lipps told *The Politic*.

Lipps described a theoretical potential juror who had been the victim of a burglary in the past. "The court's question is always, 'Notwithstanding the fact you've been burglarized before, can you put that experience aside and judge this case solely on the facts and the law?' And the potential juror says, 'yes.' And so you don't have a challenge for cause. But you think 'no way do I want this person on my jury,' so you do a peremptory strike."

Andrew Gordon, a public defender and the Deputy Director for Community Legal Services at The Legal Rights Center in Minneapolis, said that he used peremptory challenges to allow his defendants to have a role in creating the jury that would ultimately convict or acquit them.

If Gordon likes a prospective juror but his client doesn't trust them, "They get to call the shots, because at the end of the day, I'm not the one going to prison, they are," he explained.

Lipps said that he would use peremptory strikes to remove jurors that, in his estimation, are not going to be forgiving of the defendant. For example, Lipps sees a straight-laced "tax accountant who crosses every T and dots every I" as a potential liability. As a defense attorney "you want a teacher. You want a social worker. You want people that you perceive as sympathetic," he said.

Lipps's method is standard practice. Prosecutors and defense lawyers alike use peremptory strikes, based on their gut instincts, to curate a jury that makes both sides feel like they have a fair shot.

But gut instincts can be fertile ground for biases and stereotypes.

In his concurring opinion on the *Batson* case, Justice Thurgood Marshall wrote that the Supreme Court's decision to create the Batson rule would not be enough. He believed that, because racial bias is so often subconscious, racial discrimination in jury selection can be ended only by abolishing the use of peremptory strikes altogether.

Bright concurs with Justice Marshall's assessment. He has faced many prosecutors who did not recognize the influence of their implicit biases on their decision to strike Black potential jurors.

"A lot of times," he said, "a prosecutor may not even realize that when they look at an African American they may associate certain things with that person because of race."



While he believes prosecutors do use peremptory strikes explicitly to remove Black jurors because of their race, Bright also feels that the ubiquity of implicit bias is one of the biggest barriers to *Batson* effectively stopping the abuse of peremptory strikes. He observed that when relying on gut instincts, "it is impossible to say exactly why you struck a person and that race was not a part of your thinking."

Yet even among those who agree that peremptory strikes facilitate bias, many disagree about whether they should be eradicated and what the implications would be, if so.

"No one other than Marshall — no defense attorney and no prosecutor — wants to get rid of peremptory challenges," said Lipps, who argued a peremptory challenge case with Bright in the late 1980s. "But maybe that's where we should go."

Semel believes that 35 years after Justice Marshall suggested getting rid of peremptory strikes, actualizing this now may lead to unintended consequences. "As a political matter," she said, "they are so entrenched that we may not be prepared for how we will try cases fairly without them."

Although peremptory strikes allow bias into a system that is supposed to be unbiased, getting rid of them may merely shift whose biases are represented. Semel predicts that the same thinly-veiled racial reasons that judges have determined as neutral and therefore permissible for a peremptory strike would become acceptable grounds for cause challenges in the absence of peremptory strikes.

She further explained that abolishing peremptory strikes would be so controversial that the political battle, whether in the courts, Congress, or state legislatures, would be long and costly, taking away from efforts to solve other issues of systemic injustice.

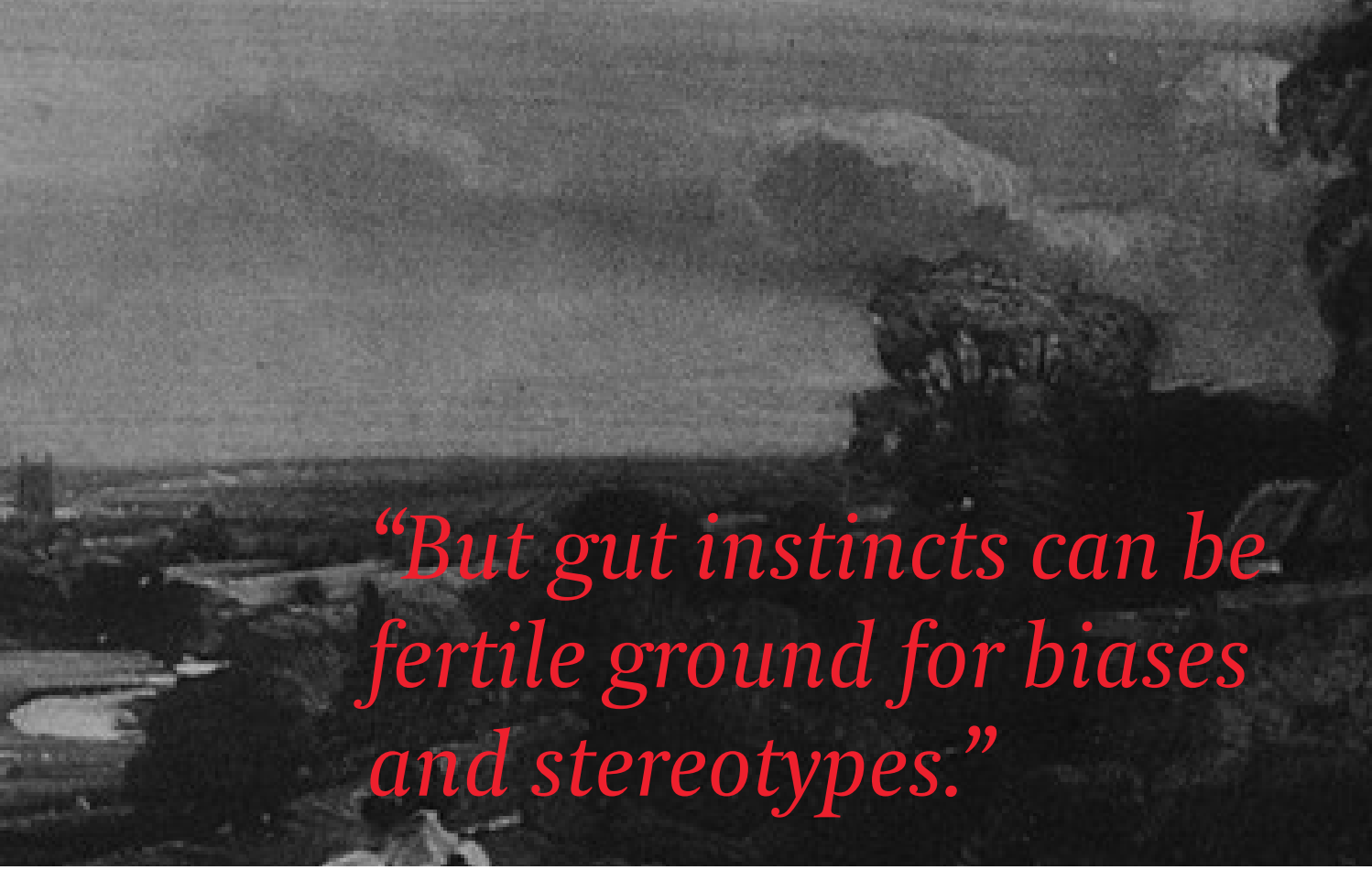
Semel and her student co-authors advocated for a different solution to California's peremptory strike problem. Based on a General Rule 37 created by the Washington State Supreme Court in 2018, her team helped create California Assembly Bill 3070, which was signed into law by Governor Gavin Newsom on September 30, 2020.

Mirroring General Rule 37, A.B. 3070 will alter the process for raising a Batson challenge to make it less difficult to prove racial discrimination and make invalid any peremptory strikes for reasons which are most directly related to race, including expressing distrust of law enforcement, having family members or friends who have been arrested or convicted of a crime, living in the defendant's neighborhood, having a child out of wedlock, receiving state benefits, lacking employment, and being a non-native English speaker.

G.R. 37 and A.B. 3070 have promising potential to improve access for all Americans to their constitutional rights of serving on juries and being tried by a jury of their peers. But even advocates of these bills fear they will not be enough.

According to Emma Tolman, a co-author of "Whitewashing the Jury Box" and former student of Professor Semel, it is likely that prosecutors will find loopholes in A.B. 3070 and — just as they did in *Batson* — use them to continue to exclude people of color from juries. "District attorneys are skilled at figuring out ways to be within the constraints of the law, but not necessarily within the spirit of the law," she told *The Politic*.

Yet, if prosecutors acted only within the spirit of the law and bills restricting the use of peremptory were air-tight, most juries would still not



"But gut instincts can be fertile ground for biases and stereotypes."

represent a fair cross-section of the population—the legal standard for a jury of one's peers.

Peremptory strikes are just one of many factors at every level of the legal system preventing the diversification of juries. In fact, "if we are not looking until people are actually in the courthouse, we are missing a huge part of the exclusionary process," Semel explained. Often, by the time the venire—the larger jury pool— is brought in and prosecutors can begin striking potential jurors, racial inequity and structural imbalances have already laid the ground for miscarriages of justice.

Most jurisdictions select names randomly from lists of citizens that other government agencies have already compiled: these lists notoriously underrepresent certain groups of people. Voter registration rolls systematically exclude Black residents who have been disenfranchised for decades. Relying on DMV registrations often leaves out low-income individuals who do not have driver's licenses or other official documentation. Tax return databases exclude unemployed people from consideration.

Even if a person's name does appear on a particular jurisdiction's list, if they do not have secure housing, their address may be out of date, and they may never receive their summons.

Gordon, the Minneapolis public defender, said that in his county, Hennepin County, the venire is selected from voter rolls and the lists of driver's licenses and state IDs from the Department of Vehicle Services.

"Those are the systemic barriers," he said. "And even when folks do get a summons, there's still significant problems within getting that person to respond."

Gordon described a conversation he had with the mother of one of his defendants. She asked him what the likelihood was that there would be any Black jurors in his trial — that her son would truly have a jury of his peers — and Gordon had to tell her that the chances were slim.

"Even when you get a jury summons into the hands of an individual who is typically a person of color, is impoverished, is indigent, may have other stressors going on in their lives, those individuals," the ones perhaps most representative of the defendant but underrepresented on the jury, "will often choose to ignore jury summons because of those stressors, and especially financial stress."

The mother admitted to him that she had not appeared for a jury summons herself when she could not afford to miss work.

"It was a choice between going to jury summons and getting $20 a day, or working and then paying the rent," Gordon recalled her explaining. "And I sat across my table and looked at her and I said, 'Well, that's a choice that not just you make, right? That's a choice that a lot of people are faced with if they get the jury summons.'"

And if, despite the countless obstacles, a person of color or low-income individual makes it into the courthouse, the chances are high that they will be sent immediately away by a peremptory strike.

In 2021, racial discrimination in jury selection remains as consequential as it was in 1986. In March, this issue was on full display in the trial of Derek Chauvin for the murder of George Floyd.

"What you have to know about the Chauvin jury selection is that it went exactly as one would have expected it to go," said Gordon. "There was nothing strange about it. I think it highlighted very well the flaws inherent in the system."

All potential jurors filled out extensive questionnaires, a common practice in high-profile trials, and were then subject to in-person questioning. It was at this point that one potential juror, Ju-

ror No. 76, was removed from the venire by the defense.

Juror No. 76 was an African American man who lived in South Minneapolis, the neighborhood where Floyd was killed. He described to the courtroom how when Black men were arrested or killed in the city, police officers were known to ride through the neighborhood in their squad cars blasting "Another One Bites The Dust."

The recollection, said Gordon, was "reflective of how law enforcement treats Black people in his community."

Chauvin's defense attorney Eric Nelson attempted to strike Juror No. 76 for cause, but his strike was denied by the judge. Nelson then successfully used a peremptory strike to remove the juror.

"The court effectively, in removing him, was basically telling a majority of the population here, folks who live in South Minneapolis, folks who live in North Minneapolis, folks who look and talk like George Floyd, that your experiences make you biased, that you cannot be fair and impartial, that you would not be able to render justice in this case," said Gordon.

"I think the galling part for a lot of people is that we were being told that we were incapable of getting to justice because of our experiences with law enforcement," he continued.

Gordon's experience is consistent with that assertion that potential Black jurors are often removed from juries under Batson for "race neutral" reasons that are, in reality, intrinsically tied to their life experiences as people of color. A first step to holding lawyers and judges accountable for the appropriate use of peremptory strikes, Gordon argued, is strengthening the Batson rule.

"We have to change our definition of race neutral," he said. "We have to understand that when a prosecutor or a defense attorney says they're removing a Black person because they have particular experiences with law enforcement, it is not a race neutral reason, because those experiences were informed predominantly by the color of their skin, by their ethnicity, oftentimes by where they live."

Gordon also discounted other classic examples of "race-neutral" accusations, such as living in high-crime neighborhoods, as similarly race-mediated. The fallacy of "race-neutral" points to the necessity of reevaluating legal standards.

"For a long time, we've thought that the way to achieve the best decision, the fair decision, the just decision, is to find people who are 'fair and impartial,'" said Gordon. "There is now enough information about how groups actually make decisions that I think the gold standard should no longer be 'fair and impartial.'"

Rather, he said, the gold standard for the composition of juries should be one that prioritizes jurors' ability to reach just conclusions, which derives from not excluding those with life experiences similar to the defendant's own—not penalizing them for their life experiences.

"We know groups make better decisions when those groups are comprised of diverse individuals. That's what we should be aiming for," asserted Gordon.

Peremptory strikes, even under *Batson*, allow the perspectives and experiences of Black citizens to be shut out of deliberations in trials that decide the futures of Black defendants and the standards for prosecution of Black defendants, claiming that these perspectives prevent impartiality.

But if a nuanced understanding of the impact of systemic racism and the lived experience of people of color is considered biased, we must ask, of the legal system, of the judicial system, and of ourselves, as people who might one day comprise a jury or be judged by one: is impartiality actually desirable?

"We know groups make better decisions when those groups are comprised of diverse individuals. That's what we should be aiming for,"

PANDECONOMICS

A CONVERSATION WITH AUSTAN GOOLSBEE

Austan Goolsbee (YC '91) served as President Obama's Chair of the Council of Economic Advisers (CEA) from 2010-2011 and as a member of the President's Cabinet. During his tenure on the CEA, Goolsbee helped shape the response to the global financial crisis and the Great Recession. He is now the Robert P. Gwinn Professor of Economics at the University of Chicago's Booth School of Business.

YOU HELPED CRAFT THE OBAMA ADMINISTRATION'S RESPONSE TO THE 2008 ECONOMIC CRISIS. HOW DOES THE CURRENT PANDEMIC'S ECONOMIC FALLOUT COMPARE WITH THE 2008 CRISIS?

There are many ways that I think the financial crisis—the years 2008, 2009, 2010—is quite different from what's happening with COVID-19, and we'll get to that in a second.

But, first, there are a few facets of it which are strangely parallel. They are both crises that originated around contagion in some sense. The financial crisis was about financial contagion—if one bank failed, it was going to lead other banks to fail, and if the banks failed, then the insurance companies would fail. It was that kind of interconnection that was everyone's fear at the time.

Now, it's obviously physical contagion. The thing about that is that crises of contagion are about fear, and people's response to fear is to withdraw. In 2009, it was about financial withdrawal, people just pulling their money out. So it had the feeling of old-fashioned bank runs. This time they're pulling their physical person out of the economy, and so the service sector is collapsing.

The contagion and fear is the biggest parallel. The main difference is that 2008 was a financial crisis. A lot of the attention had to be centered on preventing financial institutions from failing and spiraling into a Great Depression. This current crisis is really the first recession we've had that's caused by something that has nothing to do with the economy. And so the sectors that are hit now look nothing like the sectors of 2009, which looked much more like a regular business cycle. This time big drivers of the collapse of GDP are sectors like healthcare—people stopped going to the doctor, they didn't want to go to the dentist. They didn't want to have somebody in their face. Before 2020, we largely viewed all of this service sector stuff—personal services, restaurants, leisure, entertainment, travel and tourism, going to the gym—as recession-proof. This time, it's driving the recession.

As a sidenote, that's why I think forecasts have been so bad. People are basically trying to jam a totally unprecedented, unusual thing into a regular business cycle model. They're asking, how fast did the economy come back in 1984 when we

BY **BRYSON WIESE**

cut interest rates? How fast did it come back in 1991 when a recession began? Those are just totally unlike this.

GIVEN THOSE SIMILARITIES AND DIFFERENCES, HOW SHOULD THE POLICY RESPONSE TO THE CURRENT CRISIS COMPARE TO 2008?

What needs to be done is not actually in the choice set of the government. You have to make people not afraid for the economy to come back, and the government can't just change a rule and say, therefore, no one is afraid. So you have to set the conditions so that now, you stop or dramatically slow the spread of the virus.

Then, you have to make people comfortable. In the Bush administration in the financial crisis and the Trump administration with the COVID-19 crisis, their series of actions undermined their credibility in a crisis. Andrew Metrick is a dear friend of mine and runs the [Yale] Program on Financial Stability. He and I worked pretty closely with Paul Volcker through the financial crisis, and Paul Volcker kept saying that in a crisis, the only asset you have is your credibility. His view was that in a non-crisis time, you want to build up your credibility—even if it's making you look bad to tell the truth—because you're going to need it someday. When everything goes wrong, if you've lost your credibility, then your announcements don't work.

The fundamental thing that needs to be done for COVID-19—like what needed to be done with the financial crisis—is yes, you got to sort out the technical aspects of the fire, but you also need to convince people that it's safe to come back. When you have a problem of credibility I think change of administration—of either party, of anything—can be a good outcome in itself. It's rebalancing.

That's all a long wind-up to say: I think what has to happen now, I've been saying it from the beginning. The number one rule of virus economics is that if you want to help the economy, you have to stop the spread of the virus. Period. Every other strategy is a failure. You can try to prioritize the economy, not health, but if you do that, you will get neither. You will get 500,000 people dead and the economy still won't be back because there is this huge component of fear of catching a fatal virus.

They've got to stop the virus, and simultaneously they've got to have what is more like disaster relief than it is stimulus. Stimulus is about jumpstarting the economy and getting it to grow. That's not really that feasible in a moment when nobody wants to go out. You have to stop the virus and then couple it with relief payments so people don't get evicted, thrown out, freeze to death. You're burning money so you don't freeze to death until you fix the furnace. And you need that relief money for as long as the virus goes. That argument—wait, didn't we pass a whole bunch of relief money last year—yes! But then the virus reemerged, continuing to rage out of control, that means we need more money. If we don't get control of the virus, we'll need even more money. That's the cost of life support.

DO YOU THINK JOURNALISTS AND POLICYMAKERS HAVE BEEN USING THOSE TWO TERMS—"RELIEF" AND "STIMULUS"—SOMEWHAT INTERCHANGEABLY?

Yes. Totally confusing the terms. You'll hear them now talking about it. Ah, the $1.9 trillion stimulus bill! And being sloppy with that language leads to mistakes in our reasoning. Once you start using the word stimulus and thinking about stimulus, it invites now—you've probably followed

this whole debate—is this going to be inflationary? Is it too big?

There I think they have in their mind, well, let's take the budgetary cost, call that stimulus, jam it through the old business cycle model from past recessions to tell us how much inflation and how much economic growth will come from it. I just think that's conceptually incorrect. In the language of stimulus, the multiplier on government spending that's in the form of handing you money—so that you can pay the rent this month and not get evicted—that has low bang for the buck. It doesn't generate any kind of output. It prevents future collapse. It prevents permanent damage.

But it's not as though all the economists and policy people have been in the right and the journalists have been in the wrong. There's a lot of confusion about the terms even among the policy people.

THIS DEBATE ABOUT THE LEVEL OF RELIEF THAT'S WARRANTED IS GOING ON EVEN WITHIN THE DEMOCRATIC PARTY. FORMER TREASURY SECRETARY LAWRENCE SUMMERS AND FORMER NATIONAL ECONOMIC COUNCIL DIRECTOR GENE SPERLING WROTE OPPOSING OP-EDS EARLIER THIS MONTH. SUMMERS HAS WARNED THAT SPENDING BIG ON STIMULUS OR RELIEF MIGHT MAKE IT DIFFICULT TO SPEND ON OTHER PRIORITIES LIKE INFRASTRUCTURE OR CLIMATE. WHERE DO YOU COME DOWN ON IT?

The Summers op-ed… [laughs] I was personally frustrated because I had written a New York Times column that came out two days before the Summers column in which I made an argument about why you should go bigger than you expect to need. The argument was that during a pandemic where there is contagion, wait and see is the absolute worst strategy you can follow.

In 2020 we followed a wait and see strategy. We passed the CARES Act. Then the virus reemerged. People said, no, it's going down, maybe we don't need more relief, let's wait and see. But of course by December, January, it's raging out of control again and the economy clearly slowed down. We started losing jobs on a monthly basis again. And it's precisely because we're going to "wait and see" what happens with something that's spreading. By the time you see it, it's too late.

Deficit spending does make sense now. We should not be raising taxes right now in the short-term to pay for the response to a short-term crisis. Biden's other campaign priorities—the Build Back Better, spending on infrastructure and climate and inequality—came with long-term plans to create revenue and avoid deficit spending, which makes sense. So I think we can pay for relief through deficit spending and still have ways of paying for other priorities.

TO WRAP UP, IS THERE AN ECONOMIC QUESTION—PANDEMIC-RELATED OR OTHERWISE—THAT YOU THINK PUNDITS AREN'T COVERING ENOUGH RIGHT NOW?

It's maybe my personal contrarian bias, but there's been all of this talk about work from home, about domestic migration, about creating domestic supply chains for masks and PPE.

My view is that anything about COVID-19 that goes against long-standing trends in the economy is likely to default back to the normal trend. Right now everyone is moving to rural and small urban areas. But urbanization is a fundamental, monotonic trend economic force — we're more productive when we're near each other. People move to cities because they can share ideas and collaborate directly. It might take two, five, ten years, but I think you're going to see companies moving back to major urban areas.

Symptoms of Inequity

BY **RUQAIYAH DAMRAH**

Hebron, Palestine, is a city of ancient dreams and broken futures. Its beautiful, twisting stone walls carry the city's biblical history, and its famous fruit and pottery fill the bustling markets. But the city, divided between an Israeli settlement and Palestinian residential areas, is severed into two governing regions by walls and fences. Political conflict tears its streets apart.

In her home in Hebron, Salma Shaheen spent winter break preparing for the spring semester of her junior year at Yale. The pandemic and the vaccination process, however, loomed heavily on her mind.

Shaheen is a Palestinian living under Israeli military occupation, which dictates her decisions at home and during travel. All winter break, she debated whether to enroll remotely or to study at Yale so that she could receive the vaccine. As a Palestinian, it was extremely unlikely that she would receive a dose in her hometown.

Less than 50 miles away, Gall Sigler, a sophomore at Yale, was not so stressed about receiving the vaccine. He received his dose at Yale, but when asked if he otherwise would have gotten a dose in his home city of Rehovot, Israel, he replied, "Oh, absolutely. And very easily."

Though separated by only a few miles, Shaheen and Sigler belong to two disparate worlds. While Sigler's world is one of advanced technology and abundant resources, Shaheen's is one of military occupation, discrimination, and precarity—a world additionally destabilized by Israel's inequitable management of COVID-19. Israel's vaccination distribution has left behind Palestinians in the Occupied Territories, illuminating the underlying systems of oppression that result from Israel's occupation.

The *New York Times*, *CNBC*, European leaders, Dr. Anthony Fauci, and other Western media outlets have praised Israel as a world leader in vaccinating its population against COVID-19 and have encouraged other countries to follow suit. This praise is not without merit: As of April 14, 57.4 percent of Israelis have received at least one dose of the COVID-19 vaccine, and 53.3 percent have received both.

Sigler's family and relatives were vaccinated in early January. As Israeli citizens, they have access to a centralized, universal healthcare system that assigns them personal ID numbers, giving them easy digital access to healthcare. His mother, aunt, and grandmother all received a text notification with a link to an app to schedule their first and second shots.

Securing vaccinations was not as easy for Shaheen's family.



COVID-19 vaccine distribution in Israel and Palestine

Both Shaheen's mother and brother are healthcare workers. Her brother, a doctor at an Israeli hospital, has still not received the vaccine, even though his Israeli colleagues have all been vaccinated. "If you're not an Arab from the West Bank, you are vaccinated," explained Shaheen.

At the beginning of the pandemic, Israel implemented a security lockdown and sent thousands of Palestinian laborers home to the West Bank — including Shaheen's brother — leaving them suddenly unemployed. However, private Israeli companies began worrying that the shortage of Palestinian workers negatively affected profits and the employment of Israelis. In mid-March, Israel and the Palestinian Authority agreed to allow 55,000 West Bank Palestinian workers to return to work in Israel on the condition that they would not return home for at least a month.

When Shaheen's brother returned to Israel, he was handed a paper that stated he would not be receiving medical insurance coverage, unlike his Israeli colleagues. If he were to contract COVID-19, he would be sent back to the West Bank, where he would not be able to receive adequate treatment due to the undeveloped healthcare system. The Israeli authorities did not establish standards for housing, healthcare, or COVID testing, leaving room for Israeli employers to exploit the workers. When Israel began rolling out vaccines, Shaheen's brother became anxious, knowing that he would not be offered the vaccine and would work in Israel unprotected.

Shaheen herself is facing the consequences of this vaccination inequity. On the first day of April, when vaccines became available to Yale students, she spent her afternoon at Blue State Coffee anxiously refreshing her MyChart account, hoping to secure a vaccine dose. "I can't get it in Palestine," she explained, worriedly tapping her fingers on the table and refreshing her phone again. If she did not receive the vaccine at Yale, she would not be vaccinated for a very long time, and this only compounded her anxiety.

While the media highlighted Israel's vaccination successes for families like Sigler's, Shaheen's family and millions of other Palestinians in the Occupied Territories face a much more grim reality.

Shaheen and her family are among the 5 million Palestinians living in the West Bank and Gaza who did not have access to the COVID-19 vaccine. Israel initially withheld vaccinations from Palestinian citizens, but at the urging of Israeli public health officials, Israel announced in late February of this year that it would vaccinate Palestinian prisoners in Israeli jails and Pal-

estinian day laborers in Israel to protect Israel's public health and security.

In March, the Palestinian Authority secured 10,000 doses of Russian-Sputnik doses for the West Bank and 2,000 for Gaza, in addition to the 20,000 sent by the United Arab Emirates. The World Health Organization is leading a Covax equitable vaccine-sharing scheme that aims to vaccinate 20 percent of the Palestinian population, with 240,000 doses of the Oxford-AstraZeneca vaccine and 37,440 doses of the Pfizer-BioNTech vaccine.

After a call for Palestinian vaccine coverage from the United Nations Human Rights Council, Israel sent 2,000 Moderna doses to the Palestinian Authority—hardly enough to vaccinate its population of 5 million.

With recent spikes in COVID-19 cases, these vaccine doses are insufficient. According to the WHO, as of March 2020, there have been over 213,000 confirmed cases of COVID-19 in the West Bank (including East Jerusalem) and more than 2,300 deaths, in addition to 77,000 confirmed cases of COVID-19 in Gaza and 650 deaths. As these numbers climb every day, so does Palestinians' anxiety about their lack of protection.

It is difficult to ignore the discriminatory nature of Israel's vaccine distribution. In addition to Palestinians, there are 600,000 settlers–including Jewish non-citizens–in the West Bank that live in illegal settlements. All of these settlers have access to the Israeli government's vaccination program, whereas many Palestinians cannot secure a dose because of the shortage in Palestine.

"Israel has an obligation to give us the vaccine," said Dr. Haidar Eid, author and associate professor of English literature at Al-Aqsa University in Gaza, in a York University panel on medical apartheid. International law validates Eid's assertion. Under Article 56 of the Fourth Geneva Convention, an occupying power must ensure "the adoption and application of the prophylactic and preventive measures necessary to combat the spread of contagious diseases and epidemics," which includes the distribution of vaccines.

Israeli officials, however, have countered by invoking the Oslo Accords. The Oslo Accords, comprising two agreements signed in 1993 and 1995 between Israel and the Palestinian Liberation Organization, state that the Palestinian Authority health ministry is responsible for the management of contagious disease in the Occupied Territories. Additionally, the PA has not asked Israel to supply them with vaccines, and Israeli public officials have used this point to justify their vaccination policies.

However, the Accords also state that "Israel and the Palestinian side shall exchange information regarding epidemics and contagious diseases, shall co-operate in combating them and shall develop methods for exchange of medical files and documents."

Additionally, many international law attorneys pointed to the hypocrisy of Israel's invocation of the Oslo Accords. Demolition of Palestinian houses, administrative detention, and the annexation of areas nominally under Palestinian control are just some examples of Israel's violations of the Oslo Accords, all of which Shaheen witnesses daily.

As a political science major attentive to the debate on the Oslo Accords and pandemic management, Sigler noted that within Israeli media and intellectual circle discourses, public officials who invoke the Accords to justify their policies are "cherry-picking what Israel wants to follow from the Oslo Accords."

"[This situation is] quite ironic and highlights the hypocrisy in this situation because… Israel has violated [the Oslo accords] from the get go, to the extent that they have rendered them practically non-void and yet now… they are actually invoking the validity of the Oslo Accords," Feda Abdelhamid-Nasser, Deputy Permanent Observer of the State of Palestine to the United Nations, said in an interview with *The Politic*.

"You can't really understand Occupied Palestine without administrative, political, and apartheid Israel."

Beyond the legal details of pandemic management, the structural barriers in Palestine must also be taken into account. The West Bank and Gaza are under an Israeli-controlled militarized system that renders Palestine incapable of managing basic healthcare, much less vaccine distribution during a global pandemic.

Dr. Claudia Chaufan, an associate professor of health policy at York University, argued that to understand the medical inequities in Palestine, one must examine all the interacting systemic factors. "I want to bring to people's attention that this is a system of complete control from the Jordan River to the Mediterranean Sea," Chaufan said in the panel alongside Eid. "You can't really understand what goes on in Occupied Palestine without understanding the legal, administrative, political, and colonial structure of apartheid Israel."

The 1973 Convention on the Suppression and Punishment of the Crime of Apartheid defined apartheid as a deliberate and systemic act of racial discrimination to create structures of dominance. Separation of populations, segregation of public spaces (such as "settler-only roads"), and enforcement of dual legal systems are key signs of an apartheid state, as documented by the UN's Economic and Social Commission for West Asia (ESCWA) report on the treatment of Palestinians. After Dr. Richard Falk, Princeton professor of international law, co-authored and released the report, it was met with immediate resistance by international supporters of Israel, and they demanded that the UN repudiate and withdraw it, which occurred very quickly.

Israel's supporters discredit the report's assertion that Israel is an apartheid state, asserting that the country's discriminatory policies are based on citizenship rather than ethnicity or race. Foreign policy analyst and author Mitchell Bard claims that because Arabs "are represented in all walks of Israeli life" and serve in government and academic positions, Israel allows freedom of movement and speech and does not discriminate based on race.

However, Palestinians in the Occupied Territories are subject to military administration, unlike the non-Arab settler population, some of whom are non-citizens. Additionally, the 1.7 million Palestinian citizens of Israel are subject to administrative policies that restrict their rights of property ownership and acquisition, marriage, and immigration.

Bard also argues that 98 percent of the 5 million Palestinians in the OTP are governed and represented by the independent Palestinian Authority, who don't afford Palestinians the rights and freedoms that Israel does for its citizens. Security actions such as checkpoints, he claims, are necessary to protect Israel's citizens from Palestinian terrorism.

However, B'Tselem's research shows otherwise. The Palestinian Authority (PA) has very minor influence and control over Palestinians' lives in the OTP. Israel essentially governs Palestinians living in these areas, yet they cannot participate in the government that determines most aspects of their lives, from which roads they can drive on to what land they can own to where they can travel. Subjugation of Palestinians in the OTP is not spelled out in law, but is a de-facto reality. Palestinians are prohibited from peaceful protesting without a permit. Travel in between nominally PA-governed territories is often impossible due to Israel's restrictions on movement. Journalist Masha Green questions how Israel can be called a democracy when "a third of its de-facto subjects" do not enjoy political rights.

Benjamin Pogrund, a journalist who studied apartheid in South Africa, wrote an article in the *New York Times* detailing why the Israeli occupation cannot be considered an apartheid, claiming that there is no intentional institutionalized racism in Israel's policies.

Three years later, Pogrund revisited his earlier claims in an interview with *Times of Israel*. Addressing Israel's annexation plan of the Jordan Valley

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“The [COVID-19] virus, which knows no borders, floods the West Bank, unleashing a terrible spread that… Palestinians are simply not prepared to deal with,”



and settlement areas, he argued that if Israel follows through with annexation, there is no question that it is apartheid. Israel has been constructing illegal settlements in the Occupied Territories and maintained de facto annexation of the West Bank long before declaring intentions to officially annex the territory.

Abdelhady-Nasser said that Israel’s discriminatory policies extend to healthcare, denying Palestinians access to the vaccine. “The reason this population is denied access to vaccines or medical care is because of who they are: Palestinians,” she said.

Shaheen’s family had been intimately familiar with obstruction to medical care even before the pandemic. A beloved storyteller and teacher, her grandfather spent hours recounting his college years in the grapevine-filled city of Halhul where he spent olive-perfumed summer evenings on the pastures he owned and soldiers patrolled the streets during the British mandate period.

When he began feeling ill a few years ago, he needed to go to an Israeli hospital to receive a diagnosis, since the hospitals in the West Bank lacked the proper diagnosing tools.

According to Eid, Israel’s military occupation results in layers of barriers that prevent health infrastructure from developing in the Occupied Territories. Electricity cuts, water contamination, housing crises, bans on medical materials, and poverty create structural barriers to the development of hospitals and medical centers.

“Health systems were fractured, starved for funds,” Chaufan said, recalling her visits to Palestine. “Israel is in full control of the supplies. If you’re a doctor and want to volunteer and help out, you have to go through a number of bureaucratic issues that Israel has full control over… you have to seek permission and [more often than not] will be denied.”

To go to an Israeli hospital, Shaheen’s grandfather had to complete a long application process to secure a permit. After waiting for several months

to hear back, he was given a permit, but was not allowed to travel with anyone else. For an 80-year-old man who could not walk well, passing through militarized checkpoints was extremely difficult, and his family waited for him in the West Bank, praying he would travel and arrive back safely.

The permit regime and physical restrictions such as walls, fences, checkpoints divide the territory into non-continuous areas, between which Palestinians cannot travel without requesting permission from Israel. As Abdelhamid-Nasser explains, this includes restrictions on traveling to secure medical treatment—restrictions that deprived Shaheed's grandfather of life-saving medical care.

Shaheen's family decided that the process of obtaining a permit for every trip and passing through checkpoints was too detrimental for her grandfather's health, so they did not seek cancer treatment from Israel. He passed away during her first year at Yale. "I learned most of the history I know from him," recalled Shaheen, her voice heavy with emotion. "He always loved Palestine but he also witnessed so much."

Her grandfather's story illustrates the everyday reality of Israel's structural barriers. "Medical apartheid is an essential part of this apartheid system," she said.

The combination of barriers to development and obstruction of movement cripples the Palestinian health system. "The [COVID-19] virus, which knows no borders, floods the West Bank, unleashing a terrible spread that… Palestinians are simply not prepared to deal with," said Chaufan. "And nobody in their sane mind would expect that a system that has been assaulted for decades is prepared to deal with that."

The West Bank exists under a military occupation that renders its residents unable to access adequate healthcare. Hospital patients and staff must acquire travel permits—which are difficult to obtain—in order to access medical facilities in East Jerusalem.

Doctors cannot purchase supplies without permission from Israel, and they are often denied. Dr. Muhammad Abu Srour, a medical doctor from a refugee camp in Bethlehem, is frustrated at how difficult it is to provide for his patients. "It's been a very difficult experience for Palestinians… under occupation… to do any process without the occupation authorities' permission," he said in an interview with *The Politic,* "like buying the different medical accessories, machines, and different medical equipment." As a result, hospitals in the West Bank faced extreme shortages of personal protective equipment, COVID-19 tests, and ventilators.

Israeli authorities also dismantle initiatives to provide access to healthcare in the West Bank. In March 2020, Israeli Civil Administration officials confiscated the tents of a field clinic in the West Bank. Ambulance and emergency medical access are often denied to Palestinians.

The healthcare crisis is even worse in Gaza.

Gaza is governed by the elected militant Islamist group Hamas. Hamas engaged in violent conflicts with Israel and Egypt, and both countries have placed Gaza under a blockade. The Palestinian Centre for Human Rights warned that Gaza will face serious consequences because of its exhausted healthcare facilities due to Israel's air, land, and sea blockade for the past 14 years.

"Even humanitarian aid to Gaza has to go through Israel," said Shaheen. "Israel controls [most of] the borders. There is nothing that enters or exits the country without Israel's approval."

Because of the siege placed on Gaza, everything must be approved by Israel before entering the city, including medical supplies. The Gaza Strip has been facing a severe lack of oxygen machines, ventilators, PPE, and hygiene products. Thirty-two percent of basic necessity drugs are not available. Israel has continuously imposed restrictions on these basic supplies from entering the Gaza Strip. Even vaccine doses are restricted from entering: on Feb 15, 2021, Israeli authorities denied the entry of 2,000 doses of the vaccine from the Palestinian Ministry of Health.

With the rapid increase of COVID-19 cases, hospitals in Gaza are ill-prepared to handle the influx of sick patients. "Gaza is collapsing," said Eid. "It only has 40 intensive care unit beds and 65 ventilators for a population of 2 million… Gaza's healthcare system was collapsing even before the pandemic." For a city in which 5,000 people live per square kilometer, there are simply not enough places to treat all the COVID-19 patients.

But the world is noticing.

On January 14, 2021, the OHCHR released a statement that "this differential access to necessary health care in the midst of the worst global health crisis in a century is unacceptable." During the same month, 15 Palestinian, Israeli, and international health and human rights organizations signed a demand that the Israeli government fulfill its legal obligation and provide vaccinations for Palestinians living under Israeli occupation. In March, the UN Secretary-General's envoy for the Middle East peace process urged the UN Security Council to support Palestinian vaccination efforts, and the UN General Assembly appointed experts who pressured Israel to distribute vaccines to the OPT. Journalists have published pieces that call out Israel for its human rights violation, in addition to the corruption within the Palestinian Authority.

Shaheen thinks this international response is long overdue.

"I was shocked that people were shocked about the vaccine [inequities]," said Shaheen. "I was like, what did you expect? The pandemic intensified everything… it was eye-opening."

Sigler was not surprised either—he grew up in Israel and has read extensively about apartheid systems and resulting healthcare inequities.

"It's very easy to portray the situation as both sides of the conflict with-

“No matter what spaces Palestinians and Israelis reach, they will always be different,” she reflected. “Our access to the vaccine, to visas, everything is so different. So even when I try to connect to these places and even if I try to make Yale my home, it’s very hard.”

out really addressing the gross power imbalance,” he said. “I felt that something like the COVID pandemic really shows that imbalance.”

Now, 14 months into the pandemic, both Shaheen and Sigler lead parallel lives at Yale. They attend Zoom seminars from the desks of their dorms, stress out over p-sets at Blue State, and chat with friends in the dining hall line. When they go back home, though, their worlds diverge once again—and Shaheen carries that knowledge with her constantly.

“No matter what spaces Palestinians and Israelis reach, they will always be different,” she reflected. “Our access to the vaccine, to visas, everything is so different. So even when I try to connect to these places and even if I try to make Yale my home, it’s very hard.”

For Shaheen, advocating for her people is not merely a matter of political debate. “I see it beyond being Palestinian: I see it as a female, as a person of color, as a Muslim,” she told *The Politic*.

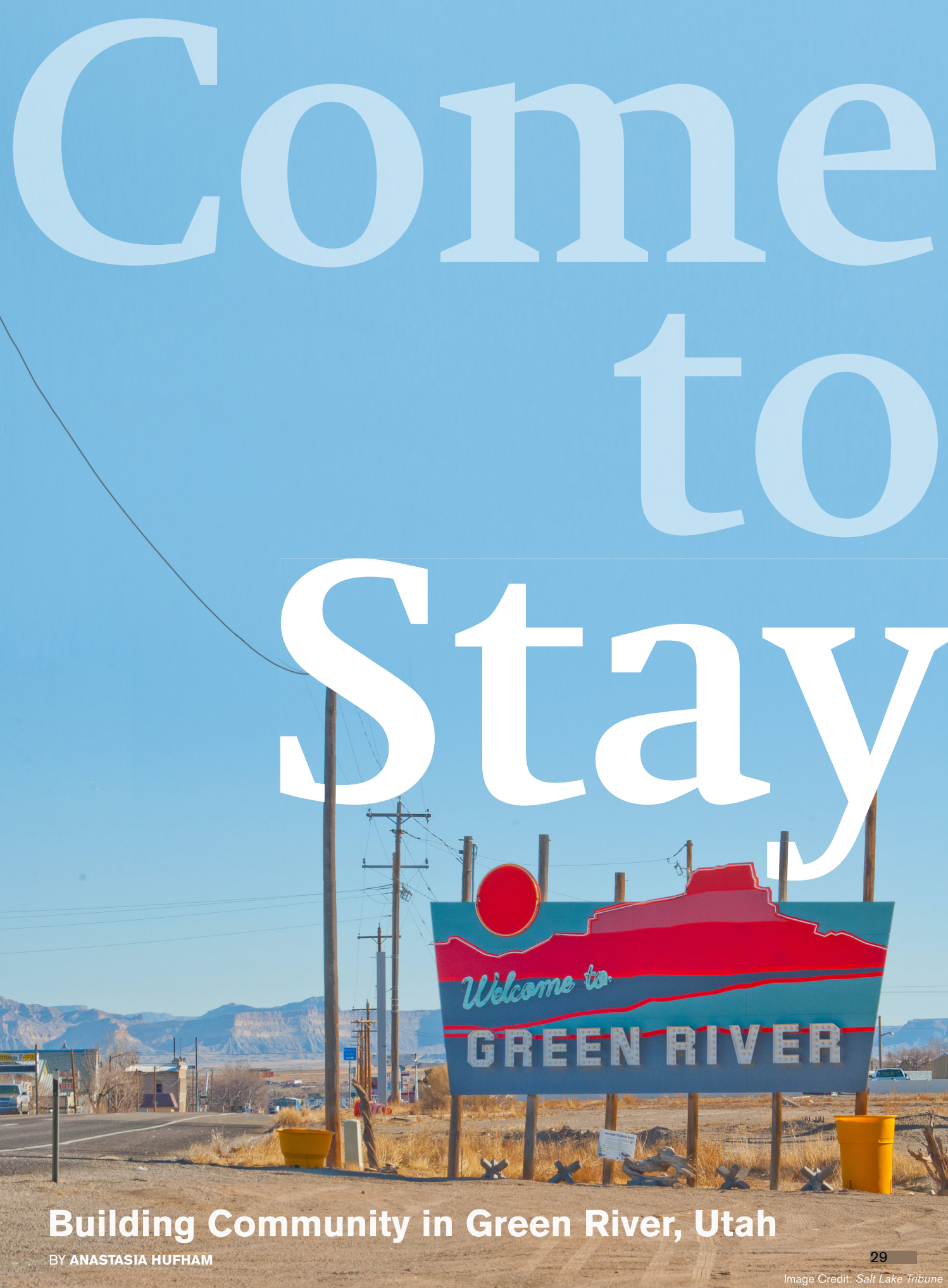
For Sigler, actively learning about and fighting for Palestinian rights feels like a responsibility. “I don’t feel consciously okay with sleeping well while knowing what’s happening close to my home,” he said. He is involved in progressive politics in Israel and actively applies knowledge from his classes to critically think about the disparities he has witnessed at home.

Despite all that separates them, Shaheen and Sigler are using their contradictory experiences to reach similar goals and navigate their careers through the lens of their past experiences, their aim to advocate for a just world that unites them—mirroring how today’s challenges in public health and beyond require collective action.

Wealthy and developed nations will overcome the pandemic and begin repairing their infrastructure and economy. It is important, however, that the international community ensures that no one is left behind to suffer the shockwaves of the pandemic. Public health responses should create global alliances that commit to equitable distribution of treatment and vaccines.

Public health is inherently collective. To fight this pandemic and future health crises, the international community should ensure that public health strategy is inclusive of vulnerable populations. After all, the pandemic is not truly over until it is over for everyone. The future of public health necessitates that Palestinians—and all historically silenced and oppressed people—are not abandoned as we move forward in creating more just, equitable global health responses.

Come to Stay



Building Community in Green River, Utah

BY **ANASTASIA HUFHAM**

Image Credit: *Salt Lake Tribune*

WHILE TRAVELING 80 MILES PER HOUR on Interstate 70 with a leaden foot on the gas pedal, it is all too easy for Utah to pass by in a blur of warm-toned rock and sagebrush. The red cliffs characteristic of Moab, Utah blend into a sandy color that glows an iridescent purple in the right light. Most billboards and road signs on the interstate point toward national parks and public lands, where millions of families per year embark on road trips to experience the heart of the American West — a land of living legends framed by dusty deserts, lush rivers, and wild mountain passes. Tucked away off the interstate in southeastern Utah sits the town of Green River: population 961, incorporated 1906.

Green River may look the same from each interstate exit, but the direction newcomers arrive from has a real impact on Green River's economy. Entering from the west, visitors are greeted by a massive Love's gas station alongside a free-standing Holiday Inn. Often, those cars fill up their tanks and promptly leave. From the east, however, Sinclair's gas station is flanked by a restaurant, motel, and a Greyhound bus stop, forcing drivers farther into town, where they might spend time at the town's restaurants, museum, or state park.

"The gas stations are the largest employers in Green River, which is nuts," said Maria Sykes, co-founder and executive director of Epicenter, a nonprofit dedicated to preserving and building upon the uniqueness of Green River through affordable housing and other projects. Sykes graduated from the Auburn University School of Architecture right before the recession hit in 2008 and visited an architecture school friend in Green River soon afterwards. That visit became a summer, and that summer ultimately turned into 12 years.

Cruising off of Green River's main street to Broadway in Sykes' gray pick-up truck, which is peppered with stickers reading "All Y'all" and "War Eagle" that reflect her Southern roots, we pass Chow Hound, Ray's Bar, the Green River Coffee Company, and the post office — "that's the social center of Green River, since nobody has mailboxes here." Epicenter's white brick building then appears on the right.

Epicenter's building originally housed a construction office, "which feels fitting — especially when building a lot of houses," Sykes told *The Politic*. That same construction company built much of Green River's city center, but "these concrete blocks are not the best," Sykes noted as she opened the door to the building. An abundance of natural light illuminates the "Rural and Proud" memorabilia on the room's desks, large center table, and March Madness brackets pasted on the walls. (Steph Crabtree, Epicenter's deputy director, won the Epicenter competition this year.)

"When we first got this building, the roof was caving in and the foundation was completely blown out. Everybody was like, 'you should just tear that building down and build something new,'" Sykes laughed. "But where would the fun be in that?"

To Sykes, it's no coincidence that Epicenter and the company who originally built Green River share a home. The building's reuse mirrors Epicenter's overall ethos: not to impose unnatural changes to or improve Green River condescendingly, or to make it more palatable for tourists, but to invest in the town from a place of love for the people who are already here.

Epicenter works to strengthen Green River's existing assets by providing affordable housing and community-building. The organization also hopes to act as a model for rural communities throughout the country, so that other small towns can build on their existing vibrancy and opportunities by providing affordable housing and other services for their residents. One of those projects is building "breadcrumbs," as Sykes calls them, to draw people into the town beyond the Love' on the west side of Green River. Another project, and their most ambitious yet, is Canal Commons, a pocket neighborhood of ten single-family homes on the town's historic canal.

Towns across America like Green River are home to idiosyncrasies that keep road trips interesting and families around for generations. While providing affordable housing and other development projects necessary to support Green River's current population, Epicenter also seeks to preserve this American gem.

"It just feels like the world is becoming a bit homogenous," Sykes said. But unlike anywhere else, Green River's blistering days, cool nights, sandy soil, and surprisingly plentiful water supply grow the sweetest melons around, establishing the town's melon family dynasties, many of whom still live (and farm) on the same land. The 115th Melon Days

"It just feels like the world is becoming a bit homogenous

A thoroughfare for millenia — be it water, railroads, or the interstate — the town itself is a vehicle for the stories, legends, and travelers emblematic of rural America.

Festival will take place there this September. Beyond celebrating the melon harvest, Sykes notes the importance of embracing every town's peculiarities, rather than allowing profit or decline to eclipse authenticity.

"Recognizing and lifting those things up, rather than focusing on what's wrong with a place, can be a really powerful place to start from. These houses, town events, whatever we're working on — it's always to improve the lives of the people that are here," she continued. "If that encourages other people to move here, cool. If that encourages people to come visit, spend money, and keep coming back to Green River, that's a bonus. But the focus is on the people who are already here."

Epicenter's mission to improve upon their chosen home in the middle of the Utah desert — or any rural community in the country, for that matter — may seem a pointless project to the average, city- or suburb-dwelling American. Why live in a place without mailboxes, Walmarts, or Ubers in favor of dirt roads and scorching summers?

The idea of rural development, Sykes says, is to preserve and improve quality of life while preventing different kinds of communities from disappearing — to sustain diverse American ways of life, making the world a little less homogeneous in the process.

WHILE PLANNING AND IMPLEMENTING projects like Canal Commons, Sykes has found herself contemplating how to embed the town's robust history into contemporary projects. "2020 kind of gifted us the opportunity to reflect on what we're doing," she said. "So much of our work is about looking forward, but also honoring the past. It's like time travel."

Located on ancestral Ute land near the San Rafael Swell, Green River has been contoured by thousands of years of geographic, cultural, and industrial history. Once an easy river-crossing point for Native Americans and white settlers alike, drought forced Indigenous peoples from the Green River area before Western outlaws and traders in the early 1800s traveled through the region via a trade route linking northern New Mexico to southern California. Fur trader Denis Julien left his permanent mark in 1836 by carving his name in the soft sandstone beside the river that gives the town its name.

In 1869, John Wesley Powell and his band of nine left what is now Wyoming to explore the mighty Colorado — into which the Green River flows — though only six survivors remained when the Grand Canyon spit them out in 1871. The John Wesley Powell River Museum on Green River's main street now boasts a river-runner exhibit.

At the turn of the century, the "Wild Bunch," including household names like Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid, holed up at Robbers Roost after their infamous heists, an apt name for the sandstone labyrinth of canyon walls and waterways that left lawmen stumped. Just 50 miles from the town of Green River, the outlaws loaded their six-shooters and concocted their schemes, though one Green River resident quipped that "the Roosters was the finest people you ever saw. They wouldn't harm a hair on your head — if you didn't have anything."

During the turbulent postbellum era, heading west seemed the best option for many Americans back east. The construction of the Denver and Rio Grande Western Railroad, which wound south through Green River to connect Denver and Salt Lake City, was the first of many boom-and-bust cycles that would characterize Green River's economy and population for the next century. South of town, only wooden posts remain of the lodgings that housed Chinese laborers as they toiled on the railroad. More workers and families arrived in the following years as electricity and the Midland Trail — one of the first marked transcontinental automobile routes in America — reached town.

There's one sparse area in the middle of town, "a little underdeveloped and weird" according to Sykes, where the river ran before it changed course in 1927. Its movement farther east left a blank, state-owned strip of land. One side features nine holes of golf, and while the state proposes building nine more on the other, Sykes would rather see a more environmentally friendly and community-centered option:

"Epicenter has been proposing a million other options, like rodeo grounds or a BMX bike course."

Mid-century decades brought American G.I.s and scientists to the area during the Colorado Plateau's uranium mining boom. On a dirt road that winds southeast, the abandoned uranium mill — which ceased operation in 1961 — remains, along with what Sykes colloquially calls the "Black Pyramid," or the Green River Uranium Disposal cell. Piled 41 feet high, the mound of radioactive tailings covered by black rock frames the sandy hills and buttes surrounding the defunct mill, which also hide military bunkers and "who knows what else" — but residents don't seem too concerned.

From 1964 to 1979, Green River became home to yet another military experiment: the Green River Launch Complex. The facility, a Cold War military subintallation of White Sands Missile Range in New Mexico, launched Pershing and Athena RTV missiles for the U.S. Air Force and Army. Today, a white Loki-Dart missile painted with U.S.A.F in black block letters stands in OK Anderson City Park to commemorate that period of Green River's history.

"I feel like there's a lot of people in town who are looking for something like this to come back. They grew up during that time, and it was like the heyday," Sykes mused about the town's military past. "Now, Green River is about hospitality, agriculture, and services. It's not thriving economically like it was, even if it's still a wonderful place to live and there are opportunities."

With the decline of the Cold War and missile industry, hundreds of workers, families, and businesses migrated away, leaving the population under a thousand residents. Interstate 70 finished construction in 1992, and tourists flooded the state to see Utah's "Mighty Five" national parks, while Green River served as a stopover in between. Moab, Utah, an hour southeast of Green River, now provides access to Arches and Canyonlands National Parks, which attract millions of visitors annually.

Today, Green River's future is wide open. A thoroughfare for millenia — be it water, railroads, or the interstate — the town itself is a vehicle for the stories, legends, and travelers emblematic of rural America. Green River's past informs its present as residents and those at Epicenter strive to preserve the history that makes the town much more than a place to fill up on gas.

IN 2009, AFTER COMPLETING THEIR TERMS as AmeriCorps volunteers in the town, Epicenter founders decided to put down roots for good in Green River. Epicenter has since been recognized by Utah governor Gary Herbert, the Utah Housing Coalition, and the National Endowment for the Arts, to name a few. At first, they came in as "idealistic outsid-



Image Credit: Ryan Baxter and Robin Hunt

ers who didn't know the town that well," according to Sykes. But by listening to and living with locals, they began to understand how Green River residents could be supported.

"Every city in the world can improve. I don't think that Green River is, like, exceptional in that it can benefit from architecture design and care," said Sykes. "There's this master narrative that rural places are in need of help or deprived. And yes, they are denied a lot of resources, but I think rural places have so many assets — things that all demographics are looking for."

To help residents and visitors alike see Green River's assets, Epicenter has completed a number of projects over the past 12 years. They were instrumental in the design and construction of the "Welcome to Green River" sign on the west side of town in 2017, now a popular place to pull over and take photos. The sign, smoldering neon pink, blue, and white, is one prized "breadcrumb" that draws visitors further into town.

"The goal is to pull people to the core of town, and once they're here, they can see what's downtown," said Sykes. Other aspects of that effort have included pop-up billboards and lit-up benches, as well as the construction of a new public safety building that houses the town's ambulance and fire department.

Pulling into the parking lot of Green River Coffee Co., Sykes points to an electric car charging station next to the building. "They tried to put those on the edge of town, but I said no," she chuckled. "They'll have to get coffee as they charge up."

The coffee shop is "our more progressive spot in town,"

"There's this master narrative that rural places are in need of help or deprived. And yes, they are denied a lot of resources, but I think rural places have so many assets — things that all demographics are looking for."



Image Credit: City of Green River

said Sykes. A yard sign in the window features an American flag reading: "In our America, all people are equal, love wins, Black lives matter."

"Like, yes, we're hicks," Sykes continued, "but we care about people."

Down the road, Tamarisk, perhaps Green River's fanciest restaurant, has stood above the river since 1979. The restaurant's view of the lavender Book Cliffs hovering over the Green River — low at the moment because of a dry spell — has always been a favorite, but has drawn new admirers following the restaurant's renovation five years ago, which included the construction of three guest rooms in the restaurant's previously unused basement.

"We do quite a bit of business development, but not in the way that an economic developer would do. We found where we and Tamarisk overlapped and built on that," said Sykes, who worked with the restaurant owners to build out the space. "For the most part, it's about finding small opportunities like that, which end up making a big difference."

Rather than booking a room at the Motel 6 down the road, visitors can now enjoy a more authentic experience by staying at the Tamarisk."They're interacting with people who are really in love with this place. Someone at Motel 6 isn't necessarily going to be nearly as excited about Green River," said Sykes.

These shorter-term projects certainly improve quality of life in Green River, but Epicenter's primary goal is to increase affordable housing throughout the town. Epicenter spends considerable time and resources collecting data on how residents and visitors interact with the town to identify and address areas of need. Their own research found that half of Main Street is vacant, and that even if 50 percent of Green River's housing units were replaced, housing would still be in chronically high demand.

"What Epicenter has done a good job of in the last 10 years is pushing back and transforming that anecdotal data into hard data that people can use to push these projects forward," said Lindsey Briceno, the project lead for Canal Commons.

Soon, a 3.2-acre plot of land directly opposite the Epicenter building will become Canal Commons, a micro-neighborhood of 10 single-family units and plenty of green space. In early 2020, the nonprofit struck a deal with the city, the parcel's prior owner, to trade labor instead of buying the parcel outright; Epicenter volunteers pledged to help write grants for the town, sit on various municipal communities, and assist with other odd jobs that will total to the 109,000-dollar value of the Canal Commons land. Despite the pandemic, Epicenter still managed to break ground in June. Sykes expects construction on the first five units to wrap up this summer.

"I know it's always chaos with development, but it feels particularly chaotic during a pandemic. It's always one hiccup after another," Sykes said, and then exclaimed: "The water's in the canal! That happened yesterday."

Many Green River residents buy into the idea that if a new project comes to the town — another uranium boom or missile base — the companies involved will provide more housing for the area, explained Steph Crabtree, Epicenter deputy director and March Madness champion.

To disprove that myth, Crabtree took note of each time someone asked her personally about housing opportunities in Green River. "I took those numbers to the city council — hundreds of requests within three months," she said. "Those were all the opportunities we were missing out on. Temporary workers would come and stay in an RV until they transferred out because there was no housing here, and they couldn't bring their families."

One lucky state trooper working in Green River years ago found a place to live, bought a house, and moved his family to the town. "That could have been repeated many times over if we'd had more housing available," Crabtree said. "Housing, even beyond economic development, is community development. If you buy a house, you're much more invested in this place."

Instead of using the term "rural development," which Sykes explained can come across as condescending, she has

> "The sense of accountability and lack of anonymity here really makes you **stubborn.** It makes you not want to give up."

Escaping the copy-and-paste, formulaic approach to development in urban areas isn't something Green River residents reserve for weekends.

taken to saying "local investment" instead. "Investing" in the town's existing resources, history, and potential has proved more productive when collaborating with residents than terminology suggesting that Green River is somehow unfinished or lacking.

"Through speaking to investors and contractors for our projects, we've learned that a lot of people don't know how rural communities operate," Briceno explained. "We don't have the same resources as people working in an urban space. So we have to get people to Green River to show them what's special about it — then they want to invest in our community."

Epicenter practices this delicate balance of statistics and storytelling through grant writing. "There are so many rural communities in this country applying for the same grants we are, many of which are also around 900 people and have had a history of booms and busts," Crabtree said. "We've done great work creating language for grants to put more emotion into our applications. Green River residents are entrepreneurs and cowboys and more, and we get way more emotion out of that."

Potential investors visit Green River, meet the ranchers and melon farmers whose family histories have been bound to the area across generations, and feel the passion pouring from Briceno, Crabtree, and Sykes. Then, real change (and real housing developments) can break ground.

The singularities of small town America, like the melons and frontier history of Green River, bring in support, investment, and resources from those with no stake in these places. The same quirks that attract people to Green River keep them there, in a sort of "chicken or the egg" cycle.

"If you invest here once, you'll find even more reasons to invest here. Housing is economic development. If you help provide housing to this community, the impact will be so phenomenal that you'll have even more opportunities to invest," Briceno said, as Sykes nodded along. "If we invest a little more into rural places, even more opportunities will come."

EPICENTER LAUNCHED FIX IT FIRST, one of its first initiatives, in 2012 as a response to anecdotal data showing that 49 percent of houses in Green River were in need of repairs. The program intended to help disabled, elderly, moderate- to low-income residents complete basic home repairs before minor damages could become major problems. Though well-intentioned and successful, Epicenter learned valuable lessons about the community they sought to strengthen.

"People here very much want to do things for themselves. One of the challenges Epicenter had coming in is that we were outsiders trying to create change," said Crabtree. "We pushed the Fix It First program really hard for a while, but it wasn't really received by the community. We've learned to offer our help in a more passive way by connecting people with the resources they need."

As the organization has matured, the people at its center have continually fine-tuned their approach to the locals, which often requires analyzing their own positionality and privilege with regard to race, gender, class, and education.

"The first thing you have to do with housing is realize that it doesn't matter if you know this person or not — everyone needs a good place to live," Briceno said earnestly. "If you come from a place of privilege, you can't look at someone's past and tell them that they shouldn't have done what they did, or ask why they have this history of mistakes." Some tenants may have bad credit or criminal records, but that doesn't make them any less deserving of a home.

Many of Green River's hospitality workers, who often work two or three jobs, belong to the Latinx community, which makes up roughly 20 percent of the population. Some don't have social security numbers and are inherently, and justifiably, distrustful of those offering help with no strings attached.

So Epicenter learned how to take a step back in that way and a step forward in others. Allowing community members the space to figure certain problems out for themselves while being available as a resource has allowed for more open community dialogue.

"Some folks just come in the door and ask if we can help them with something, and then we do, and slowly we can build a relationship over time," said Sykes. "But we've learned not to actively go to people who are less privileged than us and ask how we can help because that would be offensive. That's presuming they want or need help."

The intimate scale of Green River's community — fewer than a thousand residents — means that locals have no problem holding Epicenter accountable or voicing their opinions. When locals run into Sykes at the coffee shop, post office, or anywhere in between, they are quick to confront her when they feel wronged or belittled.

"It's full-on reckoning. We've been called out by the community, and then realized it was stupid of us to do or think something. We're always adapting and learning from

that," said Sykes. "The sense of accountability and lack of anonymity here really makes you stubborn. It makes you not want to give up."

As a result, Sykes and her team have moved on from just wanting to help Green River. "I live here now. I'm a community member," said Sykes. Epicenter's projects, along with their failures or successes, belong to her as much as those who have lived in the town for generations. "I'm in it for the long haul."

Sykes and her team have found that those who are struggling in Green River more fully understand Epicenter's mission and goals. Residents without the privilege of a stable government job, a healthy retirement fund, or family nest eggs have noticed the need for affordable housing in the town, while well-off residents have displayed an "if it ain't broke, don't fix it" mentality.

"They're the people with jobs at the Department of Transportation that are never going to be taken from them. They're never going to get fired," said Crabtree. "To them, Green River doesn't need change."

Even city representatives took time to accept the fact that Green River is in critical need of affordable housing, largely due to stigma surrounding government-funded housing in the area, which has suffered from sporadic ownership and maintenance. What Epicenter had to explain to local politicians, Crabtree explained, was that those problems had nothing to do with the tenants being low-income.

"There are a lot of people who will never come around, and that's fine, because I probably don't like them either," Sykes laughed. "But it's healthy to listen to those people. I'll listen to what some curmudgeon says and a couple of years later I'm like, 'damn it, they were right.'"

Beyond Green River, America is full of small towns and barely-incorporated communities — from the flat wheat fields of Kansas and the rocky cliffs of Maine to the drizzly farmlands of Washington and the pine forests of Alabama.

Strengthening America's foundational communities and industries pays for itself. By focusing on the people already living in these areas, whether it be for a few years or a few centuries, architects, developers, and scientists alike can develop specific approaches for preserving these places. But keeping a mindset of conservation rather than condescension — of augmenting existing assets rather than forcing new ones — seems to be the code that Epicenter has cracked.

Many Americans might look at Epicenter's work and wonder, to what end? Why?

To that question, Sykes would pose another: "Why do you vacation in a rural place? Why are these the places you go when you have precious time off?"

Because the river winds through their backyards, towering buttes frame the view out their windows, and the corner store cashier knows their names. Because escaping the copy-and-paste, formulaic approach to development in urban areas isn't something Green River residents reserve for weekends.

"People think that they want to live in a city, but when you really ask them what they want, they're all characteristics of rural places, like community. They've just been told that the city is where they need to be if they want opportunities," said Sykes. "The city is my vacation; that's my time to go to the movies and eat sushi."

If she had focused her work in developing urban areas, Sykes continued, she would have quit her job long ago. Developing a rural area means having to optimize on limited resources, like moving electric car chargers to the middle of town, and being strategic about which public spaces to create, like advocating for rodeo grounds or a BMX park. s

"In a city, I wouldn't be connecting with people in such a personal way and then seeing them at the grocery store or post office," Sykes said. "I don't feel like we're experimenting on our town, but on ourselves, finding the needs and gaps we can fill."

Driving east on Main Street just after sunset, cerulean cursive neon words bordered by luminous clouds on the side of Green River Coffee Co. glow through the darkness. The script reads "instead of loneliness I feel loveliness" — a quote from Edward Abbey's *Desert Solitude*. For Sykes and thousands across the country, rural communities represent the opposite of loneliness. Investing in them is a way to show up for those around us — to sustain the places we call home as well as the pit stops on the way to our final destinations.

Heading back southeast, the cliffs darken to a shadow on the horizon beneath a smattering of stars that mimic the neon signs left behind. Cars boasting license plates from Pennsylvania to California race by at speeds much greater than 80 miles per hour, hurtling towards the mountains of Colorado, the Great Plains of Nebraska, or the skyscrapers of the East Coast. Green River is a transient half-thought for the driver as they glance out the window at the river the town is named for — a river that has cut through ageless rock, carrying silt and travelers and stories across the West. The town may become a transient half-thought for passersby, but for the people who live there, that's the point.



Rural communities represent

the opposite of loneliness.

Investing in them is a way to show up for those around us — to sustain the places we call home as well as the pit stops on the way to our final destinations.

Image Credit: Lisa Ward

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